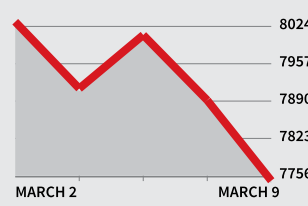


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 77566.16 (-1352.74)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	24028.05	-422.40
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.29	-0.38
US Dollar (in ₹)	92.32	+0.58
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	158039.00	-76
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	260056.00	-667

BUMPER HARVEST.

Wheat output may rise to a new high of 120 mt, exceeding the govt’s target of 119 mt, on higher area, good weather **p8**



CRUCIAL REVIEW.

Social media ban falls within national jurisdiction, will look at State laws: MeitY’s Krishnan **p10**

QUICKLY.

LOGISTICS SNAG

Egg shipments to West Asia diverted; prices drop



Bengaluru: The diversion of about 80 egg-laden containers bound for West Asia from Kochi to Mumbai port has raised concerns among farmers and exporters of Tamil Nadu’s Namakkal region, who have sought the intervention of Apeda to help ensure that the cargo reaches the intended destinations. This is even as the prices of eggs have dropped by about 20 per cent over the past fortnight. **p3**

INFLATION STILL SOFT

No big hit seen from oil price surge: FM to LS

New Delhi: With inflation remaining near the lower bound of the target band, the impact of the recent surge in crude oil prices is not expected to be substantial at this stage, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman informed the Lok Sabha on Monday. **p2**

Crude on boil scalds markets; Sensex down 1.7%, volatility up

SELL-OFF. Nifty tanks 422 points as key West Asia producers cut oil output, shut refineries

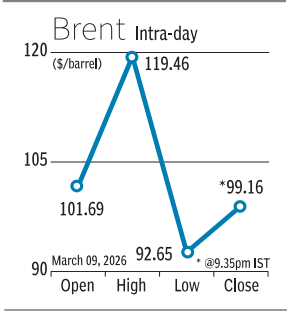
Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Markets had one of their worst single-day selloffs on Monday as a spike in crude oil prices, triggered by the escalating US/Israel–Iran conflict, sent benchmark indices tumbling and pushed volatility to a nine-month high. Risk-off sentiment also weighed on global equities.

The BSE Sensex crashed 1.71 per cent to close at 77,566.16, while the Nifty 50 fell 1.73 per cent to 24,028.05.

Across Asia, South Korea’s Kospi was the worst hit, plunging over 8 per cent intra-day before closing nearly 6 per cent lower. Japan’s Nikkei fell 5.2 per cent, while other regional markets declined between 0.75 per cent and 3 per cent. The India VIX (volatility index) surged 17.51 per cent to 23.36, reflecting heightened investor nervousness.

Brent crude surged to around \$119 per barrel, the highest since July 2022. WTI crude jumped nearly 30 per cent intra-day.

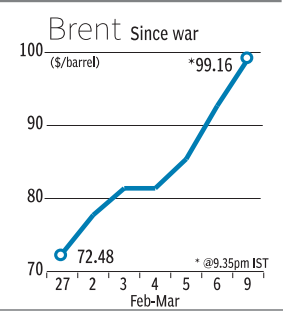


Shipping through the Strait of Hormuz remained suspended, Saudi Arabia shut its largest refinery, Qatar halted liquefied natural gas (LNG) operations, and the UAE and Kuwait joined Iraq in output cuts.

G7 TO RELEASE OIL

Crude prices later retreated from intra-day highs after reports that G7 nations are considering a coordinated release of emergency oil reserves to stabilise markets, with at least three members, including the US, backing the move. Brent fell about \$13 from its peak of \$119 per barrel following the reports.

Cooling crude prices helped Indian markets trim losses. The Nifty, which slid



to an intra-day low of 23,697.80, recovered over 330 points late in the session to reclaim the 24,000 mark.

Kaynat Chainwala, AVP-Commodity Research at Kotak Securities, said that the disruptions in West Asia could remove over 4 million barrels per day of crude supply, along with significant LNG volumes, potentially pushing prices higher.

FPI SELL, SECTOR LOSS

Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) sold ₹6,345 crore worth of shares on Monday, according to provisional BSE data, while domestic institutional investors bought ₹9,013.8 crore.

Nifty PSU Bank and Nifty Auto led sectoral losses, fall-

All-round weakness

	Close	% Change
Nifty 50	24028.05	-1.73
BSE Sensex	77566.16	-1.71
Nifty Bank	56019.8	-3.05
India VIX	234275	17.84
Japan	52728.72	-5.2
Korea	5251.87	-5.96
Nifty MidCap100	56265.5	-1.97
Nifty SmallCap100	16132.2	-2.22

ing 2-4 per cent, along with the capital goods, metal, oil & gas, and private bank indices. Only Nifty IT held firm.

Among the Nifty 50 stocks, major losers included Tata Motors (-5.27 per cent), UltraTech Cement (-5.25 per cent) and Maruti Suzuki (-4.67 per cent).

Gainers included Wipro, up 1.64 per cent, and Reliance Industries, which rose nearly 1 per cent.

GOLD DECLINES

Despite the geopolitical tensions, gold fell 1.07 per cent to \$5,097.91/ounce (about ₹1,51,203/10 g), while silver declined 0.54 per cent to \$83.44/oz (around ₹2,47,494/kg).

Rupee closes at a record low despite RBI intervention; G-Sec yields ease after rising

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The rupee and the Government Securities (G-Secs) market felt the impact of rising crude oil prices on Monday.

The Indian unit ended the day at an all-time low of 92.32 per US dollar, down 58 paise against the previous close of 91.74. G-Sec yields rose, but pulled back half the losses.

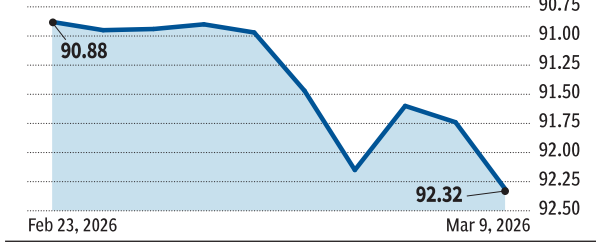
RBI INTERVENES

The central bank is understood to have intervened in the market, selling dollars through state-owned banks to smoothen rupee volatility.

K Arvind, Executive Vice-President (Head – Treasury), noted that the geopolitical and geo-economic impact of the Iran war and its impact on energy prices is still unfolding and highly uncertain. The rupee is expected to weaken unless the RBI intervenes.

He said the RBI is believed to have intervened at every level — 92.20, 92.30 — to break the rupee’s fall, ensuring that the domestic cur-

New low



rency moves in an orderly manner against the dollar.

Arvind observed that the rupee is under pressure as exporter payments are not happening, dollar outflows on account of FPI selling in domestic equity markets are continuing, and the greenback is strengthening against all major currencies.

G-SEC YIELDS SOFTEN

G-Sec yields rose as market players factored in the inflationary effect of high crude oil prices and the depreciating rupee. However, yields softened due to the RBI accepting aggressive cut-offs at the OMO purchase auction of G-Secs (for infusing ₹50,000 crore liquidity into the banking system).

The yield of the benchmark 10-year G-Sec (6.48 per cent GS 2035), which touched an intra-day high of 6.76 per cent, closed at 6.72 per cent, up 3 basis points over the previous close of 6.69 per cent.

Venkatakrishnan Srinivasan, Founder and Managing Partner, Rockfort Fincap LLP, observed that the benchmark 10-year G-Sec came under pressure in the morning session, with the yield going up to around 6.76 per cent, largely reacting to global risk cues.

However, yields pulled back later and the benchmark G-Sec closed around 6.72 per cent, supported by the outcome of the RBI’s OMO purchase auction.

IMPACT OF SOARING OIL PRICES.

Losses of Indian airlines can widen in FY26 : ICRA

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Industry-wide losses of Indian airlines could worsen in FY26 due to the disruption in international traffic, weak rupee and rising crude oil prices. Rating agency ICRA believes that Indian carriers could report a higher-than-previously estimated net loss of ₹17,000-18,000 crore in FY26.

On Monday, crude oil price surged past \$100 per barrel for the first time in four years with the disruption of production and supply from West Asia. Stocks of InterGlobe Aviation (IndiGo) and SpiceJet fell 3.4 and 6.64 per cent on Monday, mirroring the performance of airline stocks in the Asia-Pacific region.

Read more p2

No gas: Fertilizer plants advance upkeep shutdown

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad/Kochi/New Delhi/Mumbai

The government’s decision to cut gas supply for industrial use is seen lowering production by fertilizer companies and pushing up prices during the kharif season.

Many large fertilizer producers have advanced their annual maintenance schedules by a month and closed plants due to the non-availability of gas.

An official of the Indian Farmers Fertiliser Cooperative Limited, on condition of anonymity, clarified that overall production will not be affected, provided gas supply normalises by April when the company originally had planned to close the plant for maintenance.

Details p2

Gas-based petrochem units feel the heat

Richa Mishra
Janaki Krishnan
Hyderabad / Mumbai

Soaring energy prices and the logistical crisis are likely to put India’s petrochemicals sector under stress even as domestic demand remains resilient. If the Gulf conflict continues, the industry will face severe margin compression and operational disruptions.

Troubles could come from feedstock and cost pressures, though most have shifted their petrochemical feedstock from naphtha to the more cost-effective ethane.

The input costs for naphtha, ethylene and benzene have soared, tracking Brent crude. Asian spot LNG prices have spiked, impacting gas-dependent plants.

Details p2

Bengaluru hotels shut shop on LPG supply disruption

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Hotels across Bengaluru are set to remain closed from Tuesday until further notice, following a disruption in the supply of commercial liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) cylinders, the Bengaluru Hotel Association said on Monday.

According to the Association, oil marketing companies have halted the supply of commercial gas cylinders for 70 days, leaving hotels and eateries unable to operate their kitchens.

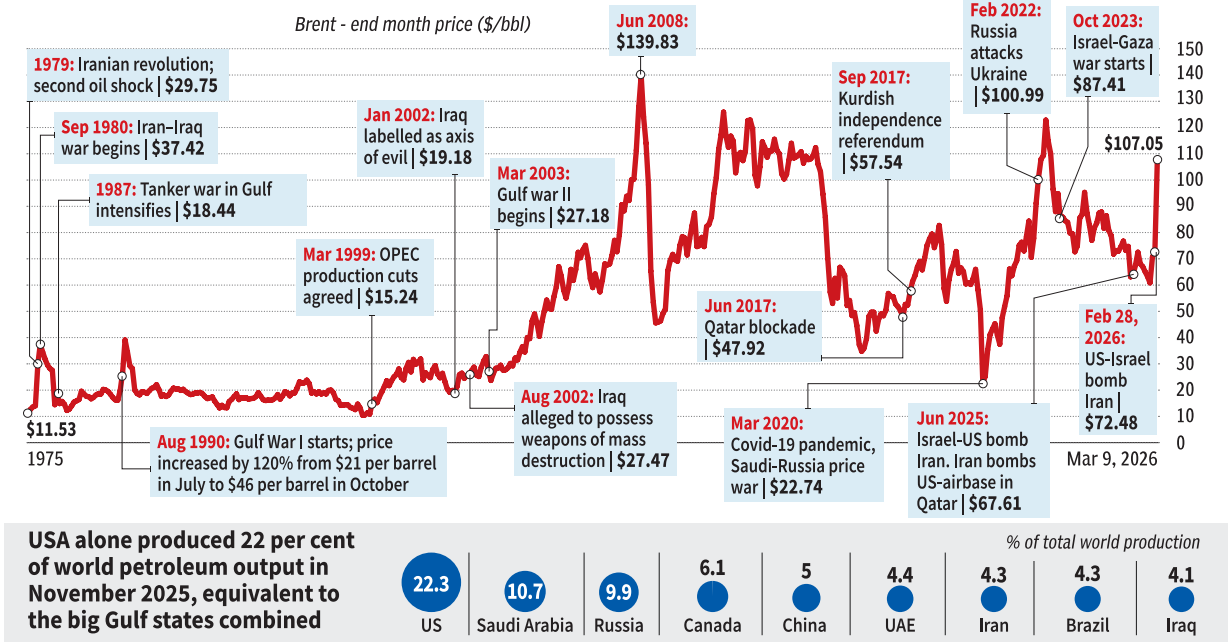
The hoteliers’ body urged Union Ministers to intervene and ensure the immediate restoration of commercial LPG supplies.

VISUALLY.

Compiled by **Sourashis Banerjee** | Graphic **KS Gunasekar**

War and oil shocks

As the US-Israel-Iran war rages in West Asia, Brent crude prices are threatening to go through the roof. More than the damage to lives, infrastructure and other facilities, it is the fear of disruption to supply which seems to spook oil markets, as was seen on Monday. In both the first and second Gulf wars, crude oil prices had more than doubled as oil supply came under threat. But beside geopolitical tensions, supply cuts by large blocs such as OPEC also seem to cause oil price shocks



1,250 Gulf-bound fruit containers stranded at Nhava Sheva port; pallets stuck at airports

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

More than 1,250 sea containers carrying fruits, such as bananas, grapes and pomegranates, meant for the West Asian markets during the holy month of Ramadan are stranded at the Nhava Sheva port near Mumbai with shipping services disrupted by the Iran war.

Pallets of fruits are also stuck at several airports as Gulf-based airlines suspended operations to the region.

Ramadan is a peak season for Indian fruits, and exporters are worried about the fate of large volumes stuck at ports and airports. The mango season is also set to begin.

According to Nhava Sheva port sources, about 1,500 TEUs (twenty-foot equivalent

units) are lying in the terminal, of which around 1,250 are carrying fruits. The value of the stranded cargo could not be ascertained.

Most fruit exports from India to West Asia move through Nhava Sheva to Jebel Ali in Dubai, with a usual transit time of two-three days. Consignments, mainly of bananas, grapes and pomegranates, are stored in reefer containers that remain plugged in, ensuring the cargo stays safe for now, sources said. But a prolonged delay could be disastrous.

RAMADAN DEMAND HIT

For exporters, Ramadan is among the busiest periods as the West Asia demand surges. The war has, however, created a major disruption. Shipments have been delayed, logistics costs have

risen, and buyers are cautious about placing fresh orders.

Exporters say a large share of their annual business depends on Ramadan sales. If exports slow during this period, the produce may have to be diverted to the domestic market where prices are significantly lower and there may not be enough demand to absorb the volumes.

Sources said two ships are expected to sail to a port in Oman in the next couple of days, and some fruit consignments may be loaded onto those vessels.

AIR CARGO DISRUPTION

While the disruption is smaller as compared with sea freight, air shipments of fruits and vegetables have also been affected. India lifts several hundred tonnes of fruits and vegetables daily

to West Asia. Flights were completely disrupted in the initial days of the conflict, though there has been some normalisation recently.

“Shipments to Oman are least affected. With Emirates resuming some flights, the capacity crunch has eased somewhat, though still far from normal. Air freight costs to Europe are 50-70 per cent higher than two weeks ago,” said Kaushal Khakhar, CEO of Mumbai-based Kay Bee Exports.

According to CK Govil, CMD of Delhi-based Activair Airfreight India Pvt Ltd, many farmers who planned to export produce during Ramadan have been unable to do so. “Some airlines that are operating have increased freight rates four-five times to nearly ₹1,000 per kg for shipments to Europe and the US,” he said.

Govt prioritises LPG for home use; directs all refiners to step up production of gas

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

As the conflict in West Asia entered its tenth day with no signs of de-escalation, the government has begun prioritising LPG for household cooking needs, introducing measures such as increasing the minimum waiting period for booking a cylinder to 25 days from 15, and giving preference to domestic consumption over commercial use.

Top sources said that the LPG situation remained comfortable with “no alarm right now”.

However, with no indication that the Strait of Hormuz disruption will ease soon, the government is taking precautionary steps to prioritise supplies for households.

Last week, refiners were directed to prioritise propane and butane for producing LPG and deliver the supplies only to Indian Oil Corporation, Bharat Petroleum Corporation and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation.

On Monday, the government revised this order, directing all domestic or SEZ oil refining companies, including petrochemical complexes, to maximise LPG production.

They have been asked to ensure that the entire production of C3 and C4 streams, including propane, butane, propylene and butenes, available at their refineries and petrochemical complexes is utilised for LPG production.

“We have raised the minimum lock-in period for booking a LPG cylinder to 25

days to check hoarding. The earlier lock-in period was 15 days, which was raised to 21 days. An order will also be issued very soon to prioritise consumption for households over commercial use,” said one of the sources.

Explaining the rationale, an official said that in a non-PMUY household, one 14.2-kg cylinder typically lasts up to 55 days, giving consumers sufficient time to plan refills. The longer lock-in period is also expected to prevent panic buying and artificial scarcity in the market.

IMPORTS DIVERSIFIED

India, the world’s second-largest LPG importer, sources up to 90 per cent of its supplies from West Asia.

However, the government is now exploring cargoes from “wherever possible”, including the US and

Canada, another source added.

India, the world’s third-largest LPG consumer, burnt more than 33 million tonnes (mt) of the fuel in FY25, with over 90 per cent consumed by households for cooking.

Domestic production stood at 12.79 mt, while 20.67 mt was imported during the year.

COMFORTABLE ON LNG

The government said it has “comfortable” stocks of liquefied natural gas (LNG) and is actively procuring additional cargoes, including from the US and Canada.

Oil Minister HS Puri said on X: “Uninterrupted energy imports are flowing into India from routes that are not impacted by the conflict and we are taking all necessary steps to ensure availability of energy to our citizens.”

Cut in gas supply forces fertilizer cos to advance maintenance work

GROUND REALITY. Companies confident of meeting kharif season demand even as price spike fears linger

Our Bureaus
Ahmedabad / Kochi /
New Delhi / Mumbai

The government’s decision to cut gas supply for industrial use is seen lowering production by fertilizer companies and pushing up prices during the kharif season. Many large fertilizer producers have advanced their annual maintenance schedule by a month and closed plants due to the non-availability of gas.

An IFFCO official, on the condition of anonymity, clarified that overall production will not get affected, provided the gas supply normalises by April when the company originally had planned to close the plant for maintenance.

Sources in the fertilizer industry said that urea plants, which make the fertilizer mainly on imported gas, are currently getting 30-50



AIDING GROWTH. As of February, India’s urea stocks stood at 5.5 million tonnes against 4.9 mt in the same period last year

per cent of their requirement. Sources said the government has informed fertilizer companies not to make public the issue of non-availability of gas. Queries sent to the Fertilizer Association of India were not replied till evening.

UREA PRODUCTION
India has 32 functional urea manufacturing plants, of which 31 use gas as their feedstock, while one takes coal-gassification route to

produce nitrogen. S Sakthi-
mani, Chairman and Managing Director, Fertilisers and Chemicals Travancore (FACT), said the company uses three key inputs — rock phosphate, sulphur and RLNG — and has sufficient stock currently.

FACT has tied up with countries such as Togo for the supply of rock phosphate, and has enough stocks to meet production needs for the next three months. BPCL has assured adequate supply

of sulphur, while RLNG supply has been moderated due to prioritisation to other sectors, he told *businessline*.

This is the off-season for fertilizers, and the company is undertaking maintenance activities at its plants. “We will be in a position to cater to market requirements in the coming season in June-July,” he said, adding that FACT currently holds about 1.4 lakh tonnes of fertilizer stocks.

Gujarat Narmada Valley Fertilizers & Chemicals sources a significant portion of its ammonia production from natural gas, which accounts for about 60 per cent of total ammonia output, said official sources.

Earlier this month, GNFC reported that supply constraints from its RLNG supplier, GAIL (India), triggered by a *force majeure* notice from Petronet LNG. While the company indicated that production of neem-coated

urea could be impacted, other product lines were largely unaffected and the overall impact remains uncertain.

Officials of the state-promoted Gujarat State Fertilizers & Chemicals declined to comment on the potential impact of the Strait of Hormuz closure on natural gas availability.

The inventory available with fertilizer companies seems comfortable before the kharif season begins. As of February, India’s urea stocks stood at 5.5 million tonnes against 4.9 mt in the same period last year. Inventory of DAP was at 2.5 mt against 1.3 mt recorded last year. However, stocks of muriate of potash were lower at 1.29 mt (1.5 mt).

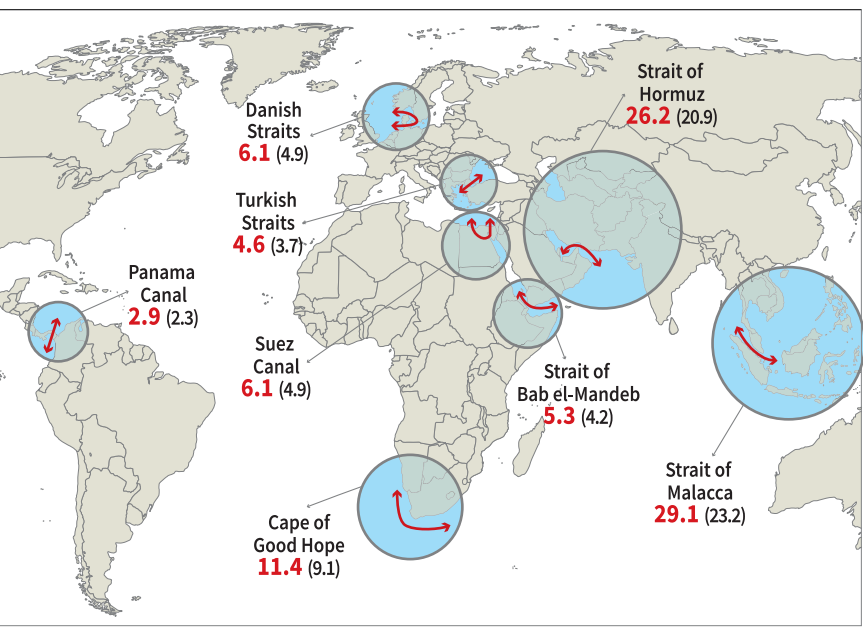
India’s annual fertilizer consumption is around 65 mt. Urea accounts for nearly 40 mt of this demand, while DAP consumption is about 10 mt.

VISUALLY.

Compiled by **Sourashis Banerjee** | Graphic **KS Gunasekar**

World energy arteries

Strait of Malacca followed by Strait of Hormuz form the most critical choke points in global maritime energy trade



West Asian countries collectively have the largest oil reserves, leading to conflicts for the ownership of the precious resource

Venezuela	3,03,221	UAE	1,13,000	Nigeria	37,280	Algeria	12,200
Saudi Arabia	2,67,200	Kuwait	1,01,500	Kazakhstan	30,000	Ecuador	8,273
Iran	2,08,600	Russia	80,000	China	28,182	Azerbaijan	7,000
Canada	1,63,000	Libya	48,363	Qatar	25,244	Norway	6,912
Iraq	1,45,019	US	45,014	Brazil	15,894	India	4,981

Proven petroleum reserves in the world 2024 (billion barrels)

Sources: EIA, OPEC, Bloomberg, IMF, World Bank

Gas-based petrochemical units feel the heat of rising conflict in West Asia

Richa Mishra
Janaki Krishnan
Hyderabad / Mumbai

Soaring energy prices and logistics crisis are likely to put the Indian petrochemical sector under stress even as domestic demand remains resilient. If the global conflict continues, the industry will face severe margin compression and operational disruptions.

Most of the gas-based petrochemical units are feeling the strain, analysts said. Today, India has emerged as a significant global hub, currently ranking as the sixth-largest chemical producer in

the world. Mukesh Ambani-led Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL) is India’s largest integrated producer. Public sector major Indian Oil Corporation (IOCL) is expanding rapidly into downstream petrochemicals while West Bengal-based Haldia Petrochemicals is a major manufacturer of polyethylene and other chemical intermediates. Besides these, GAIL (India) Ltd, though primarily focused on natural gas, is a key producer of polymers. There are also specialised producers.

COST PRESSURES
Troubles for the sector could come from feedstock and

cost pressure, though most have shifted their petrochemical feedstock from naphtha to more cost-effective ethane.

The input costs for naphtha, ethylene and benzene have soared alongside Brent crude. Asian spot LNG prices have spiked significantly, heavily impacting gas-dependent plants. According to industry sources, this will lead to production costs rising by 10-20 per cent which, in turn, will put pressure on margins.

Umad Shokri, Senior Visiting Fellow at George Mason University, said: “High oil prices, now around \$108 per barrel amid the Iran-Is-

rael-US war, are disrupting petrochemical supply chains globally due to Strait of Hormuz restrictions and strikes on key facilities like Iran’s South Pars and Israel’s Haifa refinery.”

“Shortages of feedstock — naphtha, LPG and methanol — have triggered *force majeure* in Asia (70-80 per cent reliant on West Asia imports) and production cuts worldwide, driving up ethylene and derivative prices while increasing volatility. Asia faces acute shortages and export halts, Europe grapples with margin squeezes from limited alternatives, and the US sees short-term gains but broader

economic ripple effects from inflation and slowed demand,” he said.

SUPPLY RISKS
According to information available, India is heavily exposed to supply risks from the Gulf for critical items such as methanol (87.7 per cent) and ethylene glycol (nearly 100 per cent). Demand is primarily driven by the need for ethylene, a key building block for plastics, packaging and automotive parts.

RIL, the primary driver of demand, co-owns a fleet of very large ethane carriers (VLECs) to secure its supply chain. Sources told *business-*

line that most of its requirement comes from the US. This means the transit time is longer, but supplies continue uninterrupted. It is routing it through the Cape of Good Hope.

Restrictions on shipments through the Strait of Hormuz due to the ongoing war in West Asia has forced the conglomerate to take this step. Using the Cape of Good Hope lengthens the time to supplies and is also more expensive, but sources indicated that there are no alternatives.

It could not be ascertained how much of ethane stocks it holds and how long they would last, but sources said

they were not facing shortage at the moment. The company is also figuring out the logistics of transporting propane and butane for home consumption.

The government has directed that gas supply should be prioritised for home consumption and cut down industrial requirements.

GAIL (India), which operates a major integrated, gas-based petrochemical complex at Pata, Uttar Pradesh, is likely to run below capacity and also adopt rationing. Its other venture, Brahmaputra Cracker and Polymer Ltd (BCPL) in Assam — in which it holds a 70 per cent stake — is gas-based but also runs on

naphtha and, therefore, may not face immediate severe impact. ONGC Petro-additions Ltd (OPaL) in Dahej, Gujarat, where GAIL is a co-promoter, has also suffered severe strains.

“We do not see immediate impact on financials in March. We are continuously monitoring the effect of the war on feedstock and product prices and will assess the impact on financial performance going forward,” said Navanin Narayan, Whole-time Director & CEO, Haldia Petrochemicals Ltd.

With inputs from Mithun Das Gupta in Kolkata

Inflation at ‘lower end’; no big hit seen from oil price surge, says Sitharaman

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

With inflation remaining near the lower bound of the target band, the impact of the recent surge in crude oil prices is not expected to be substantial at this stage, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman informed the Lok Sabha on Monday.

Though the written reply was prepared prior to the latest surge, it did coincide with the Brent crude prices spiking about 25 per cent to \$116.50 per barrel.

RISE IN CRUDE PRICES

According to the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC), the international price of the Indian crude basket stood at \$99.12 per barrel

on March 6. A comparison of the average daily prices in February and March shows that the Indian basket has become costlier by more than 27 per cent. India imports over 85 per cent of its crude oil requirement, making the economy sensitive to global price movements.

In her reply, Sitharaman said global crude prices had been on a declining trajectory over the past year until the situation in West Asia changed on February 28.

“Between the end of February and March 2, the crude oil FOB price (Indian Basket) rose from \$69.01 per barrel to \$80.16. Given that India’s inflation is near the lower bound, the impact on inflation is not estimated to be substantial at this point,” she said. India’s targeted in-



Finance Minister
Nirmala Sitharaman

flation range is 2-6 per cent, with 4 per cent as the midpoint. Retail inflation, measured by the CPI with the new 2024 base year, stood at 2.75 per cent in January. The February data will be released on March 12. While the weight of the housing, water, electricity, gas and other fuels category has risen to 17.66 per cent from 16.91 per cent in

the new CPI series, the actual impact of fuel prices can be higher due to their multiplier effect across the economy, influencing the headline inflation number.

Quoting RBI’s Monetary Policy Report of October 2025, Sitharaman said a 10 per cent increase in crude oil prices, assuming full pass-through to domestic prices, could raise inflation by about 30 basis points.

“The medium-term impact of the global crude oil price rise on inflation depends on several factors, including exchange rate movements, global demand-supply conditions, monetary policy transmission, the state of general inflation, and the extent of indirect pass-through,” she said.

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

The sharp depreciation of the rupee against the dollar has cushioned domestic bullion prices from the impact of global slide in gold prices.

The rupee depreciated to an all-time closing low of 92.32 against the US dollar, losing 58 paise on Monday, as the conflict in West Asia worsened with Iran putting pressure on neighbouring countries to tame US aggression.

Gold prices in the US were down 1.2 per cent to \$5,098 an ounce after shedding 2 per cent in the earlier session as dollar strengthened against major currencies.

In the futures market, gold April contract dropped

to \$5,112 an ounce. Silver was down 2 per cent at \$82 per ounce. Despite the growing crisis, gold prices fell as investors preferred to book-profit after prolonged rally.

SPOT GOLD PRICE
However, in India, spot gold prices were down marginally by ₹77 at ₹158,674 per 10 grams against ₹158,751, according to the Indian Bullion and Jewellers Association. Silver slipped by ₹667 to ₹260,056 per kg against ₹260,723 on Friday.

Prithviraj Kothari, President, India Bullion and Jewellers Association, said domestic domestic bullion prices are derived from international spot prices, but are adjusted for the USD/INR exchange rate, import duty and GST. With the ru-

pee weakening to around ₹92 per dollar, largely due to rising crude oil prices and capital outflows, the currency effect is offsetting the decline in international prices, he said.

Manav Modi, Commodities Analyst, Motilal Oswal Financial Services, said the disparity in domestic and international prices was largely due to rupee depreciation against the dollar, which made gold prices costlier than the international market and somewhat covered the dip in global prices. This apart, he said the volatility in rupee-dollar prices led to variations in bullion prices. The rupee traded at 90.50 against the dollar a couple of weeks ago and moved down sharply to about 92.5 now, he added.

Double hit for paper makers: Costlier energy, loss of market

Our Bureau
Kochi

The West Asian crisis is likely to have a significant impact on India’s paper industry, creating a dual challenge of rising energy costs and possible disruptions in key export markets. Paper and paperboard exports could slow down as West Asia remains one of the most important destinations for Indian paper shipments.

In 2024-25, India exported paper and paperboard worth about \$980 million, of which nearly \$290 million, or 30 per cent, was destined for West Asian markets. Major export segments include uncoated writing and printing paper, coated paper and paperboard and kraft paper.

At the same time, the sector, which is highly energy-intensive and closely tied to global trade flows, is expected to feel the ripple effects of the escalating geopolitical tensions in the region. Rising energy prices triggered by the crisis could directly increase production costs for domestic paper mills. Since energy accounts for a substantial share of operating expenses in the industry, any prolonged rise in fuel and power costs is likely to put pressure on margins and affect competitiveness.

The crisis is also expected to lead to higher ocean freight rates due to increased fuel costs, higher insurance premiums and longer shipping routes arising from disruptions in established maritime corridors.

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Last-minute airspace curbs force IndiGo to divert Europe flights

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

A Manchester-bound IndiGo flight returned to Delhi after over seven hours in the air and another aircraft was diverted to Cairo after being denied overflight permission by the air traffic control in Eritrea.

IndiGo restarted wide-body flights to Amsterdam, Manchester and London on Sunday after seven days. These flights are operated by Boeing 787 planes leased from Norwegian airline Norse Atlantic. They avoid Gulf airspace, in line with the European Aviation Safety Agency recommendations.

While IndiGo’s Sunday flights operated normally, a confusion over overflight permission disrupted travel plans of travellers on Monday. The aircraft operating on the Delhi-Manchester



flight returned after flying till Ethiopia, while a London-Delhi route was diverted to Cairo.

IndiGo said the Manchester-bound aircraft returned due to last-minute airspace restrictions. “We are working with relevant authorities to explore the possibilities of resuming the journey,” said IndiGo.

REPATRIATION FLIGHTS
Around 90,000 passengers returned to India following partial resumption of services. While Jeddah, Muscat

Around 90,000 passengers have returned to India following the partial resumption of air services

and UAE airports are functioning, the first scheduled flight from Doha arrived in Delhi on Monday. On Tuesday, Qatar Airways plans to operate flights to Kochi, Delhi and Mumbai.

Responding to a question in the Lok Sabha, Civil Aviation Minister Ram Mohan Naidu Kinjarapu said on Monday that the DGCA had engaged with all airlines, and that multiple meetings had been held to ensure safe operations. All possible steps are being taken for the repatriation of stranded passengers, he added.

Iran war can raise airlines’ losses, says ICRA

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Industry-wide losses of Indian carriers could worsen in FY26 due to disruption in international traffic, weak rupee and rising crude oil price. Rating agency ICRA believes Indian airlines could report a higher-than-previously estimated net loss of ₹17,000-18,000 crore in FY26.

On Monday, the crude oil price surged past \$100 per barrel for the first time in four years with the disruption of petroleum production and supply from West Asia. Stocks of InterGlobe Aviation (IndiGo) and SpiceJet fell 3.4 and 6.64 per cent on Monday, mirroring the performance of other airline stocks in the Asia-Pacific region.

“Around 15-20 per cent of Indian aviation industry’s revenue is generated from flights travelling through the West Asian airspace, and the



IN LIMBO. Between February 28 and March 5, Indian carriers cancelled 1,770 overseas flights

disruptions have resulted in not just revenue loss but also higher costs owing to additional airport charges and additional fuel cost due to longer routings,” said Kinjal Shah, Senior V-P and co-group head (corporate ratings), ICRA Ltd.

FLIGHTS CANCELLED
Between February 28 and March 5, Indian carriers cancelled 1,770 overseas flights

₹17,000-18,000 crore in FY26,” Shah added

FARE CAPS
Fuel expenses account for 30-35 per cent of airline operating expenses. Aircraft lease and maintenance expenses are dollar-denominated, and thus depreciation pushes up airline expenses. Jet fuel prices in March are up 5.7 per cent on a month-on-month basis.

“I will not be surprised if oil companies revise the rates in the middle of March. The government should now lift the cap on airfares that it had imposed at the time of the IndiGo flight disruption,” a senior airline executive remarked.

Indian Oil Corporation did not respond to a query on price revision. Along with the removal of fare caps, airlines have asked the Civil Aviation Ministry for tax relief on jet fuel prices and rationalisation of airport fees and navigation charges.

‘Energy security, trade key factors in West Asia strategy’

SAFETY FIRST. Well-being of Indian community is priority: MEA

Amiti Sen
New Delhi



STEADFAST COMMITMENT. External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar (left) in the Rajya Sabha in New Delhi on Monday ANI

Addressing a stormy session of the Rajya Sabha on the escalating conflict in West Asia on Monday, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said India’s strategy in dealing with the situation centred on securing the country’s national interest, including energy security, trade flows and security of Indian nationals.

The Minister outlined a three-pronged approach to the West Asia crisis, reiterating a firm commitment to peace and de-escalation through a return to dialogue and diplomacy to protect civilian lives.

“Our national interest, including energy security and trade flows, will always be paramount factor..The well-being and security of the Indian community in the region is our priority. We will continue to work with the governments of the region towards it,” the Minister said.

IRANIAN VESSELS

Jaishankar also addressed the issue of Iranian vessels docking at Indian ports. “The Iranian side requested permission on February 28 for three ships in the region to dock at our ports. This was accorded on March 1. *IRIS Lavan* docked on March 4 in Kochi. The crew is currently

in Indian Navy facilities. We believe this was the right thing to do and the Iranian Foreign Minister has expressed his country’s thanks for the human gesture,” he said.

The Prime Minister continues to closely monitor the emerging developments, and relevant ministries are co-ordinating to ensure effective responses, the Minister said amid heated sloganeering from Opposition members.

Opposition leaders, led by Mallikarjun Kharge (Rajya Sabha), and the INDIA bloc argued that a mere ministerial statement was insufficient and sought a short-duration discussion on the war and emerging challenges to India’s energy security to ask direct questions and seek immediate clarifications.

The interest of Indian consumers has and will always be the overriding priority, the Minister said.

“Where required, Indian diplomacy has supported the endeavours of our energy enterprises in this volatile situation,” he added.

HIGH-LEVEL DIPLOMACY

He emphasised that India was engaging in high-level diplomacy, including direct contact with the Iranian leadership, to safeguard its national interests and the lives of millions of citizens.

“...Contacts with Iran at the leadership level are obviously difficult at this time. I have, however, spoken to Foreign Minister Araghchi on February 28 and March 5, 2026. We will continue these high-level conversations in the coming days,” Jaishankar said.

“Till yesterday, almost 67,000 of our nationals have crossed the international borders to return. Every effort is being made to bring back our people from West Asia,” he affirmed.

War hits egg exports to West Asia

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru



Exporters have sought Apeda's help after 80 egg containers from Kochi to West Asia were diverted to Mumbai

The diversion of about 80 egg-laden containers bound for West Asia from Kochi to Mumbai port has raised concerns among farmers and exporters in the Namakkal region. They have sought the intervention of Apeda to help ensure that the cargo reaches the intended destination.

This is even as prices of eggs have dropped by about 20 per cent over the past fortnight due to the disruption in the export supply chain as a result of the ongoing war in West Asia and the seasonal slowdown in domestic consumption.

“The war has created a big problem. No port is accepting the containers as no shipping lines are operating. About 10 days ago, we transported about 80 containers of eggs from Kochi to various destinations such as Dubai, Bahrain, Oman and West Africa. Due to the war, the ships were diverted to Nava Sheva port in Mumbai, from where we were asked to take the containers as the shipping lines cannot proceed further. We have urged Apeda to look into this issue,” said Valsan Parameswaran, Secretary of the All India Poultry Exporters Association.

The Apeda Chairman and the team of officials have assured them that the egg containers would be shifted to the vessel that would be leaving Mumbai port on March 11, Parameswaran said.

Close to 5 lakh eggs can be packed in a container, and the shelf life is about 90 days. “The problem is that we are already late by 10 days now due to these transit issues,” Parameswaran said.

He added that the developments had triggered concerns among exporters and the poultry farmers.

EXPORTERS’ PLEA

Further, poultry exporters have also urged the government to consider eggs as an essential commodity and support the industry with the additional freight rate of \$4,000 per container that is being charged by the shipping lines.

Meanwhile, egg prices have dropped by around 20 per cent over the past two weeks due to disruption in the export supply chain following the start of the war in West Asia.

Prices have come down from ₹530 to ₹430 per 100 eggs as per the NECC data.

“Prices do come down this time of the year on slowing consumption due to summer, Ramadan and Easter. Due to the school holidays, off-take from mid-day meal schemes in States like Tamil Nadu gets reduced.

“However, this year, exports have been affected in recent days due to the war situation in West Asia, the main destination for Indian poultry exports,” Parameswaran said.

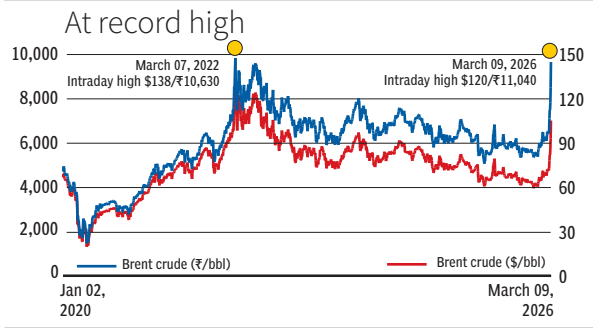
During the current financial year, India’s poultry exports are set for a new record on robust purchases by countries such as the United Arab Emirates, Indonesia and Japan.

For the first nine months of fiscal 2025-26, exports have nearly doubled than a year ago, with shipments touching a record \$237 million over \$119 million a year ago, as per the DGCIS data.

In volume terms, shipments have grown considerably to over 18.87 lakh tonnes over 6.96 lakh tonnes in the corresponding period last year.

Rupee cost of crude touches a historical peak as oil hits \$120

Nishanth Gopalakrishnan
bl. research bureau



At its current price of around \$100 per barrel, Brent Crude is trading around 28 per cent lower than the high of \$138 it hit in March 2022, right after the start of the Russia-Ukraine war, or 32 per cent cheaper than its all time high of \$148 in July 2008. But for India, the pain is not relatively less as compared to 2022 by any means. With oil touching \$120 a barrel intraday on March 9 and the rupee at ₹92 to the dollar, the rupee cost of crude was the highest ever in history at ₹11,040.

As the US-Israel-Iran war rages on with no end in sight, crude has soared over 64 per cent to \$120 a barrel from \$73, just before the start of the war. When the Russia-Ukraine war broke out, rupee was trading at ₹77 to the US dollar. With rupee having de-

preciated about 20 per cent since then to ₹92 now, oil costs the highest in rupee terms today.

Rupee cost of crude is now ₹11,040, surpassing ₹10,630 at crude’s peak during the Ukraine war. At its all-time high in 2008, the rupee cost then worked out to ₹6,364.

WHO TAKES THE HIT

The retail price of petrol was capped around ₹97 per litre in May 2022 and has remained largely range bound

at around ₹100 for four years now.

If crude oil prices continues to trade above \$100 and fuel prices remain unchanged, the impact on OMCs this time could be more intense than what played out in FY23. Industries such as aviation, FMCG, tyres, paints, plastics and logistics that depend on crude and its derivatives as inputs also won’t be spared as their margins could come under pressure.

‘Govt will not raise fuel prices’

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Even as international crude oil prices breached the psychological threshold of \$100/barrel on Monday with the West Asian conflict intensifying, the government reiterated its stand of no increase in the retail prices of diesel and petrol to shield the common man.

Top sources said there are “no immediate” plans to raise retail prices of the two auto fuels. India has 25 days stock of crude oil and petroleum products each, which is “sufficient” to weather the impact in the short term. Besides, supplies are available, including from Russian crude-at-sea.

“Of course, the cost is rising due to the war. PSU refiners have made profits in the last 2-3 years and can absorb some of the costs. They are also responsible corporate citizens,

who absorbed higher crude prices in 2022 at the peak of the Russia-Ukraine war,” said one of the sources.

The government also does not intend to stop exports of diesel, petrol and jet fuel as the domestic supply situation is comfortable “currently”. India’s petroleum product exports are generally in the range of 1.2 million barrels per day.

OIL STOCKS

Sources also said India will not participate in the G7’s effort to release crude oil stocks from the strategic petroleum reserves (SPRs) to check rising Brent crude prices, which rose to about \$119 a barrel during the day on Monday before settling at a little over \$100.

The Finance Ministers of G7 countries are scheduled to meet to deliberate on the SPR release in a bid to calm volatility in the markets.

A Quiet Revolution in Kerala THE INSPIRING INKEL STORY

From massive healthcare campuses and high-tech logistics parks to pioneering wind farms and “solar on stilts,” INKEL has pivoted from being a middling company to a “Total Solution Provider” in infrastructure.

For years, INKEL (Infrastructure Kerala Limited) was a low-profile public limited company. Established in 2008 with a high-profile mandate to harness NRI investments and build quality infrastructure in the state, yet, for nearly a decade, the engine struggled to rev up. Growth hovered at a marginal 3-4%, dividends were non-existent, and the company functioned primarily as a modest Project Management Consultancy (PMC) implementing government projects.

Fast forward to 2026, and the narrative has shifted dramatically. Today, INKEL is a debt-free, dividend-paying juggernaut with construction projects worth about ₹1,300 Cr under its belt, a strong presence in the renewable energy space, ‘BBB minus’ investment rating from CRISIL and a top-tier ranking by the Kerala State Infrastructure Investment Fund Board (KIIFB) among the State’s Special Purpose Vehicles (SPVs). From massive healthcare campuses and high-tech logistics parks to pioneering wind farms and “solar energy projects” INKEL has pivoted from being a middling company to “broader portfolios” to include logistics, real estate and renewable energy sector.

At the heart of this turnaround is its Managing Director Dr. K. Ellangovan, former Additional Chief Secretary who is ably assisted by the Board of Directors led by Shri P Rajeeve, who is also the Hon Minister for Industries, Coir and Law. The company prepared a business strategy to migrate from a Project Management Consultant to a Total Solution Provider over a period of three to five years. Chairman of INKEL and Industries Minister Rajeeve notes: “INKEL has made a big turnaround, marked by steady profitability and distribution of dividends to investors”.

Today, as part of its effort to broad base its portfolio INKEL has ventured into renewable energy sector by implementing a 20.5 MW solar energy plant in its industrial park in Malappuram to cater to some of the Extra High Tension Consumers of KSEB by providing a leveled tariff for the next 25 years. The project will have the Battery Energy Storage System (BESS) to provide grid stability besides maximising its revenue. INKEL also has in the pipeline, a hybrid Wind and Solar Energy project with a combined capacity of 36 MW energy, to be implemented in the next two years. Both the solar energy plant in Malappuram and hybrid renewable energy plant in Palakkad will be first of its kind in the state. In the area of renewable energy, INKEL has already implemented close to 30 MW solar energy projects across the state for KSEB, ANERT, Autokast and



FORMED WITH AMBITIOUS GOALS, INKEL HAS SUCCESSFULLY OVERCOME PAST CHALLENGES TO ACHIEVE CONSISTENT PROFITS AND PAY OUT DIVIDENDS. I BELIEVE THE COMPANY HAS, OVER THE LAST FIVE YEARS, FOUND THE SPARK NEEDED FOR A MAJOR BREAKTHROUGH.

P. RAJEEVE
MINISTER FOR INDUSTRIES AND LAW & CHAIRMAN, INKEL LTD.





INKEL WILL DEVELOP A STAND-ALONE ‘A DESIGN STUDIO’ AND A DETAILED PROJECT REPORT (DPR) CELL TO CATER TO A LARGE CLIENT BASE IN KERALA.

Dr. K. ELLANGO VAN
MANAGING DIRECTOR, INKEL LTD.



various local bodies.

It is also worth noting that INKEL being one of the fourteen SPVs appointed by the Government of Kerala to implement various projects, it has emerged as the ‘best performing’ SPV and was awarded an Excellence Award by KIIFB recently.

KIIFB tasked INKEL with construction of state-of-the-art buildings for government medical colleges, district hospitals and schools. The latest among these is the just-completed Cochin Cancer Research Centre (CCRC), which has a total built-up area of approximately 6.3 lakh square feet and the Super Speciality Block for the Government Medical College in Ernakulam with over 8.5 lakh square feet of built-up space.

But midway through all this, INKEL found that a big leap would be possible only if it looked beyond long-gestation infrastructure projects. Its search for immediate wins landed it in the renewable energy space. Perhaps the most poetic of its new ventures is a “solar on stilts” project, which is in developmental stage and INKEL has roped in a consultant from Singapore to do the detailing. Once this project gets implemented, all the water logged wetland, where agriculture is not possible and conversion is also not possible, could be put to use for solar energy project.

INKEL’s has a large footprint in other sectors as well through its subsidiaries and associates. One of its associate companies MIV Logistics (P) Ltd is the largest container Freight Stations (CFS) in Ernakulam, handling close to 40% of the TEUs transiting through the



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Vallarpadam container terminal in Kochi. Its another flagship subsidiary – INKEL -EKK has constructed two stretches of roads for RICK Ltd under annuity model. The JV with KSIDC in the name INKID has two industrial estates with close to 150 industrial houses functioning in Malappuram and Angamaly. INKEL has also developed a 4 lakh square feet built-up space in Angamaly to house more than 100 industrial enterprises.

“Our aim is to ensure steady revenue to the company for it to expand and grow in newer areas. In this regard, the company has identified a pipeline of projects worth ₹1300 Cr in logistics, renewable energy, battery storage and waste management to be implemented in the next three to four years”, Dr. Ellangovan points out. Plans are also underway for a massive logistics park in Palakkad to cater to the 2,000+ trucks that cross the Walayar border daily. Diversification has also led INKEL into the critical arena of waste management. Rather than acting as a front-end

collector, INKEL is positioning itself as a technology and investment coordinator, working with local bodies to convert food waste into high-value manure. Even the automotive sector is on the radar, with a detailed plan for a vehicle-scrapping and recycling facility ready to launch once the State issues vehicle scrapping notifications.

Looking forward, the company is launching two new profit centres: a Design Studio and a Detailed Project Cell. These units will allow INKEL to provide end-to-end solutions.

Dr. Ellangovan credits INKEL’s success to a coordinated action on the part of the Board of Directors and officers. Today, INKEL has a massive shareholder base of 2400 as against 800 shareholders three years back. Since 2022, the company has returned nearly ₹27 crore in dividends to the very shareholders who once doubted its viability. No doubt, INKEL’s journey is a blueprint for how State undertakings can reinvent themselves for the modern economy.

FOR ENQUIRIES

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Ides of March

Oil storm from Gulf washing up on India’s shores

Monday’s surge in crude oil prices should set the alarm bells ringing in New Delhi. The price of benchmark Brent crude shot up 25 per cent to over \$118 a barrel sending India’s stock markets and the rupee on a tailspin. Prices softened by end of day but they are still around \$105 a barrel. It is clear that oil markets are nervous.

Oil crises have never been good for the global economy. Whether it was 1973, 1979, 1991, 2008 or 2022, oil shocks have left a permanent scar impacting global growth for several years that followed. We could be looking at a repeat unless the war ends right away, which seems rather unlikely. For India, the crisis has rudely interrupted what was a Goldilocks period of rapid growth, low inflation and stable macroeconomic indicators. President Trump and Prime Minister Netanyahu, with their assault on Iran, have snatched the punch bowl away from what was set to be a rocking party for India’s economy. Robust tailwinds have now turned into strong headwinds leaving the Centre with rather difficult options to navigate through the turbulence.

High oil prices coupled with scarcity will hit the economy through multiple channels. First, of course, is the direct impact. India imports more than 90 per cent of its oil needs. While the Centre is sanguine over available stocks of crude oil and petroleum products (will last about a month), the price shock will be a nasty blow. It is estimated that a 10 per cent rise in crude price will push up inflation by 35 basis points and shave 10 basis points off GDP growth. In addition, there will be the second order impact as a range of industries from airlines and transport to fertilizers, chemicals and petrochemicals feel the pinch of scarcity and a surge in input costs. And then there is the gas economy, natural gas and cooking gas. India imports over 65 per cent of its cooking gas, most of it from the Middle-East. The Centre’s directive over the weekend to refineries to direct propane and butane for producing cooking gas is an indication of the delicate supply balance. Retail prices were also increased for both domestic and commercial consumers on Sunday. Supply of natural gas to industrial consumers has also been curtailed, which will have an impact on the economy.

The Centre has three options to manage the price shock. One, cut excise duty on fuels; two, pass on the price increase to consumers and three, fall back on the oil companies to absorb the shock. The Centre may prefer the last option as it is the least disruptive in the immediate context and there is precedent. The five national oil companies together have cash in hand of ₹95,000 crore (trailing 12 months to December 2025) but they also have net debt of about ₹4.23 lakh crore. And these companies are listed, with public shareholders. The option, therefore, can offer only limited comfort. The developing situation is probably the biggest challenge for the Centre since Covid and it needs to strategise carefully. To start with it should take citizens into confidence on the crisis they face rather than presenting an ‘all-is-normal’ face.

OTHER VOICES.

The Guardian

Hiding MPs’ staff names would undermine democracy
The recommendation that the names of MPs’ staff should be removed from a decades-old register, made by the House of Commons standards committee, is a retrograde step away from transparency. It is also appallingly timed. Public confidence in institutions including the government is fragile. A Labour MP resigned the whip just this week, after her husband was arrested on suspicion of spying. Parliamentarians should be striving to boost trust and engagement, not hiding information. The plan is all the more ill-judged as it emerged from a proposal to increase scrutiny. Currently, about 2,000 people employed by MPs, who hold passes granting them access to parliament, are named on the Register of Interests of Members’ Staff. But employees based in constituency offices with access to the parliamentary intranet, and email accounts, are not on it. LONDON, MARCH 8

讀賣新聞

This Issue Is No Longer Someone Else’s Problem
It has become apparent that foreign forces attempted to steer Japanese public opinion in directions favorable to their own countries through activities such as spreading false information on social media. If voters are swayed by false or misleading information when deciding whom to vote for, the foundations of democracy could be shaken. The government and social media platform operators must strengthen their monitoring of such information in cyberspace. During the latest House of Representatives election campaign, posts against Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi proliferated on X. These posts included statements such as, “The prime minister is buying votes from the Unification Church,” and “The prime minister has paved the way for military buildup and historical revisions.” TOKYO, MARCH 9

CAPITAL IDEAS.



RICHA MISHRA

The war between US-Israel and Iran has predictably led to an energy crisis for Asia. India is also among the three-largest energy consumers in the world — following China and the US. If the prevailing situation continues at the Strait of Hormuz, for a price-sensitive consumer like India, higher oil prices will result in a terms-of-trade deterioration, while disruption in the Strait will also hit LNG supply. India’s energy demand is growing at the fastest rate among major global economies, driven by rapid industrialisation, urbanisation, and a rising population. The country remains highly dependent on external sources, importing over 85 per cent of its crude oil and nearly 50 per cent of its natural gas (LNG). Not only will India face higher replacement costs for LNG cargoes, the price-sensitive sectors — particularly industrial users and smaller gas distributors — may need to rework their sourcing strategy.

REWORKING SUPPLY CONTRACTS
Key players such as Petronet LNG Ltd, India’s largest LNG terminal operator, have already issued *force majeure* notices to its offtakers as its vessels cannot safely navigate the Strait to reach loading ports. This has also led to major gas marketers like GAIL (India) Ltd to rework their supply to customers in priority order. According to information available, India operates eight major LNG terminals with a combined nameplate regasification and storage capacity of 52.7 MTPA (million metric tonnes per annum). India currently holds about 21 days of LNG inventory, including stocks in transit. The government, reportedly, is working on mandating all LNG terminals to maintain an additional 10 per cent storage capacity beyond day-to-day requirements. But, is this enough, given the growing demand? With the government increasing the share of natural gas in its energy mix from the current 6.7 per cent to 15 per cent by 2030, as part of its move to transition to a gas-based economy, shouldn’t there a focused approach for creating storage facilities? According to International Energy Agency, natural gas markets have gradually rebalanced in recent years following the major shock that followed Russia’s invasion of Ukraine in February 2022. A wave of new LNG capacity between now and the end of this decade



GETTY IMAGES

Govt must build gas storage on a war footing

The Middle East crisis has put a severe strain on gas supplies. Creating more storage capacity is vital for dealing with it

is expected to transform market dynamics. “But markets remained tight in the first two months of 2026, and depleted storage coming out of the heating season in the Northern Hemisphere is set to increase the call on LNG in the months ahead. An extended loss of output from the Ras Laffan facility in Qatar could significantly exacerbate this market tightness. Production was shut down following an Iranian attack on the facility on March 2,” it said. The concerns are serious. In his statement in Rajya Sabha on Monday on “The Situation in West Asia”, the External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said that “The region is key to our energy security and includes many important suppliers of oil and gas...In view of the implications of this conflict for our energy security, I also seek to address that particular concern. Government remains committed to ensuring that fully, taking into account, While storage on strategic and commercial terms has been constructed for crude oil in India, for gas it remains woefully inadequate

costs and risks of the energy markets. For us, the interests of the Indian consumer has and will always be the overriding priority. Where required, Indian diplomacy has supported the endeavours of our energy enterprises in this volatile situation.” Qatar supplies 10-11 MTPA of LNG to India, which is 45 per cent of its imports. India has long-term agreements with Qatar, US, Russia, Australia, and UAE among others. What is holding back the government from creating more storage capacity that will serve both our economic and strategic purposes? According to Rajesh Mediratta, the MD & CEO of IGX, “In India, commercial storage needs economic justification, which is seemingly looking difficult because we don’t have seasonal peaks as EU, China, US, Japan and Korea face. But I feel we should build underground storage for at least 10 per cent of our consumption or say one month equivalent of consumption. Taking our consumption as 70 bcm, 7bcm of strategic and 3 bcm of commercial, so 10 bcm of storage looks good.” In China 10 per cent storage is mandated by law for all city gas companies, he said.

NEED FOR URGENCY
While storage on strategic and commercial terms has been constructed for crude oil in India, the same is not the case for natural gas. The Oil Ministry had set up a task force to look into the matter. The Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulator Board, which plays a key role to in facilitating oil and gas distribution to promote competitive markets, create infrastructure and protect consumer interest, has been nudging the government to set up storage infrastructure for fossil fuels. “With rising consumption of gas, it is becoming imperative to create storages to meet demand during times of unexpected disruption in supply,” the Board had suggested. The Board had also made detailed presentation on the construction of the storage facilities. With rising consumption of gas, even the proposed 10 per cent storage capacity may not be enough. So before it further strains the economy, strategic storage is needed. This will not only handle supply but also to help manage the volatile LNG market. All developed economies having a significant share of gas in their energy mix have provision of 10-15 per cent gas storage. It also has commercial benefits.

Export policy should move away from subsidies

Given the current geopolitical uncertainty, focus must be on improved logistics, digital infra, and resilient supply chains

Amal Krishnan
Brinda Muralikannan
Badri Narayanan Gopalakrishnan

For decades, India’s export policy relied on incentives such as MEIS and RoDTEP, assuming price competitiveness would secure market share. Geopolitical tensions, climate-related regulations, and rising protectionism render subsidies and tax rebates increasingly inadequate as safeguards. The ongoing US-Israel war with Iran exemplifies this volatility. These shocks highlight the need for resilience over fiscal offsets. Sanctions, technology controls, and friend-shoring have already fragmented supply chains. In this environment, competitiveness hinges on resilience, compliance, and reduced structural costs. It is high time that our export policy is redesigned to make it more resilient amid challenging times. Budget 2026-27 gave early signs of the recognition of the need to build a resilient export sector by prioritising export credit, insurance, and trade infrastructure over direct transfers. A ₹7,295 crore export credit package allocated ₹5,181 crore to interest subvention and ₹2,114 crore to collateral support, easing financing for MSMEs. Customs reforms extend duty deferment from 15 to 30 days for eligible

AEO manufacturers. The ₹10 lakh cap on courier exports has been removed to boost e-commerce. Duty-free import limits for seafood processing inputs rise from 1 per cent to 3 per cent of prior-year FOB turnover, curbing input cost exposure. Advance ruling validity extends from three to five years, and trusted trader clearances expand for predictability. A ₹12.2 lakh crore public capex programme targets waterways, freight corridors, and coastal cargo to cut logistics costs (currently 7-8 per cent of GDP). The message is unequivocal: competitiveness will stem from lower finance costs, reduced port delays, and mitigated compliance risks, not post-export compensation. India’s recalibration mirrors reforms across developing economies. Vietnam has cut customs clearance to about 24 hours, and Bangladesh upgraded garment compliance and now hosts over 200 Leadership in Energy and Environmental Design (LEED) certified factories. Similarly, India could lower port dwell time below 48 hours, widen export credit coverage and build sector specific compliance capacity to secure durable competitiveness beyond subsidy reimbursements. The Budget marks the beginning of a structural transition from subsidies to systemic cost reduction, but its



TRADE. Under uncertainty | ISTOCKPHOTO

credibility will depend on measurable outcomes. **DELIVERY MATTERS** First, compliance capacity must move beyond advisory intent to measurable delivery. At least 50 major export clusters in steel, textiles, chemicals, and engineering goods should be equipped with accredited carbon accounting and life cycle assessment facilities within three years. Certification turnaround time should be reduced to under 30 days. Second, export credit and insurance support must expand quantitatively. Insured export coverage should rise to at least 50 per cent of total merchandise exports, up from current lower penetration levels, and average claim settlement time should be capped at 60 days. Interest spreads for MSME exporters should narrow by at least 100 basis points relative to current lending

rates to demonstrate real risk absorption. Third, India’s trade diplomacy must move from reactive litigation to proactive rule engagement by investing in technical trade diplomacy capacity, including sector-embedded climate and digital regulation experts, early regulatory monitoring systems, and formal impact assessments. The absence of early influence in frameworks such as CBAM shows that delayed participation reduces India’s ability to influence sector coverage, calculation methods, and transition timelines. Innovative export policies must increasingly focus on capability building rather than financial incentives. In a volatile global trading environment sustainable competitiveness will depend on regulatory readiness, digital infrastructure, and resilient supply chains. If India complements the structural reforms initiated in the Budget with forward-looking initiatives such as export resilience planning, carbon competitiveness strategies and digital trade infrastructure, its export policy could evolve from reactive support to a comprehensive framework for long-term global competitiveness.

Krishnan is an Assistant Professor and Muralikannan is a student at Christ University, Bengaluru. Gopalakrishnan is Fellow, NITI Aayog

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Powerful ‘nutty’
This refers to “The nut paradox of democracy” (March 9). In today’s democracies as much destruction is caused by ‘nutty’ heads of government with personality traits like being “eccentric, mercurial, impetuous or narcissistic” as by those who misuse power their position gives them. US President, Donald Trump, has shown scant regard not only for the judiciary in the matter of tariffs, but also for international rules and practices in waging a war with Iran. Some of his traits accentuate his inexplicable behaviour in dealing with friends and foes alike. India’s strong democratic roots have taught a lesson to those who abused

their power, as in the Emergency case, but in some states the phenomenon of twisting Constitutional power persists, as in West Bengal. However, the democratic process is too slow to get rid of them before they cause damage. **YG Chouksey**
Pune

CAD worries
This refers to the Editorial ‘Stress management’ (March 9). India’s current account deficit (CAD) is under pressure primarily due to rising crude oil prices. Continued withdrawals by Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) from Indian markets have also weakened the rupee. The

services sector remains a key cushion by generating a strong export surplus. Reducing CAD sustainably requires structural changes. India needs to significantly expand manufacturing to narrow the merchandise trade deficit, while the IT services sector must upgrade its capabilities, particularly in artificial intelligence to move beyond traditional back-office services and sustain high-value service exports in an increasingly AI-driven global economy. **Srinivasan Velamur**
Chennai

Digital guardrails
Apropos ‘I-T dept’s nationwide crackdown targets restaurants in

₹70,000 crore tax scam’ (March 9), this is a stress test of India’s tax plumbing in the age of smart billing. If a PoS system can help a diner split a bill, it can also help a business split reality, log every sale, then “forget” it before GST time. That is not clever accounting, it is ‘productised’ fraud. Enforcement must follow the data trail, but the bigger fix is upstream. Mandate tamper evident audit logs for PoS systems, certify vendors, and penalize deliberate “delete button” features the way we penalize fake weights and measures. Digital compliance needs digital guardrails, not just digital raids. **K Chidanand Kumar**
Bengaluru

Time to rejoice
Hats off to the Team India for outplaying the Kiwis successfully defend the ICC T20 World Cup title. Notably, such a splendid victory came amidst various odds that heavily favoured New Zealand team, just prior to the beginning of this most crucial cricketing encounter. However, display of some superb batting skills in the first place as also some outstanding bowling performance later, eventually put India on the driver’s seat. Congrats to team India. **Kumar Gupta**
Panchkula (Haryana)

QUICKLY.

29 VCFs pay ₹2 crore to settle case with SEBI



New Delhi: As many as 29 venture capital funds, including LICHFL Fund, on Monday settled with SEBI a case of alleged violation of VCF norms after paying nearly ₹2 crore towards settlement charges. The proceedings were related to certain VCF schemes that had not liquidated their investments within the stipulated tenure and continued to remain active beyond their expiry period. The entities included SBI Macquarie Infrastructure Trust, Canbank Venture Capital Fund, True North Fund IV, Karnataka Information Technology Ventures Capital Fund-2, Tata Capital Special Situations Fund-Trust and Gujarat Information Technology Fund. »

360 ONE Asset closes 5th private credit fund

Mumbai: Alternative asset manager 360 ONE Asset on Monday said it has closed its fifth vintage private credit strategy, raising total commitments of about ₹3,500 crore (around \$400 million), including managed assets. The commitments in the fund have come from a diversified pool including pension funds, insurance companies, family offices and high-net-worth individuals, the company said. The fund will continue the company's strategy of providing structured and customised credit solutions to the domestic corporates, with a focus on capital preservation, strong covenant structures and attractive risk-adjusted yields, it stated. »

Vedanta, Nalco, Hindalco gain as global prices rise on supply woes

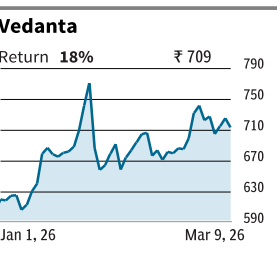
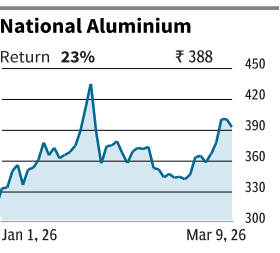
GALVANISING ELEMENT. Aluminium rate surges to multi-year highs on London Metal Exchange

Gayathri G
Chennai

Shares of aluminium producers have been on an upswing as global aluminium prices surged on supply concerns triggered by geopolitical tensions in West Asia, with stocks such as Vedanta Ltd, Hindalco Ltd and National Aluminium Company Ltd (Nalco) gaining despite broader weakness in the domestic equity markets. Even though these stocks fell around 2-3 per cent on Monday due to the overall weakness, Nalco rose 2 per cent year-to-date (YTD), Vedanta 17.7 per cent and Hindalco climbed 5.6 per cent, as against Nifty's fall of 8.1 per cent.

Aluminium prices on the London Metal Exchange have climbed to multi-year highs amid rising concerns over supply disruptions across key production hubs.

QATAR TROUBLE A key trigger was the controlled shutdown of an aluminium smelter in Qatar, operated as a joint venture between QatarEnergy and Norsk Hydro. The facility has an annual capacity of about 6.64 lakh tonnes, and its closure has heightened fears of tightening global supply chains, even as demand remains resilient. It will take at least six months to revive operations. Indian producers are seen as relatively well positioned to benefit from the rally. Domestic firms have



strong backward integration and local sourcing of key inputs, enabling them to capture higher spreads when global commodity prices rise. Vedanta is particularly sensitive to movements in global aluminium prices. It is also investing nearly ₹10,000 crore in expanding its aluminium business, including value-added capacity at Jharsuguda in Odisha, expansion at the BALCO smelter in Ch-

hattisgarh, and ongoing capacity additions at Lanjigarh. Brokerage CLSA said Vedanta is best placed to benefit from the rally given its diversified exposure across aluminium, zinc and oil. Hindalco is also expected to gain from higher aluminium prices, although analysts caution that rising gas costs and potential pressure on spreads due to disruptions in scrap exports from

West Asia, could cap the upside.

Brokerages remain divided on Hindalco, with Axis Direct and ICICI Direct maintaining a 'hold' rating, while Motilal Oswal Financial has a 'buy' call. Geojit BNP Paribas has also reiterated a 'buy' on Vedanta.

Aluminium Bahrain has declared *force majeure* due to shipping disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz, while Qatalum has announced a controlled shutdown after gas supplies were suspended. Antique Stock Broking has maintained a 'buy' on Nalco, with a target price of ₹420. Analysts said the direct impact of the West Asia conflict on India's coal or aluminium availability is likely to remain limited.

XED, first IPO from Gift City, delayed amid West Asia crisis

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

Citing "prevailing uncertainties" in the Gulf region, XED Executive Development, a leading provider of executive education, has rescheduled its IPO to March 16-24. The company initially planned to open the issue on March 6, but ongoing conflict between Iran and US-Israel prompted a delay to reduce potential market volatility and ensure smoother participation from international investors. The IPO, priced at \$10-10.5 per share, will be a dollar-denominated listing through Gift City, targeting overseas

investors under the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA) framework.

FOUNDER CONFIDENT John Kallelil, Founder and Managing Director, XED, said, "We remain confident about the offering and are committed to concluding the process successfully within this month." The offering has received approvals from Gift City-IFSC authorities and the listing exchanges, and the shares will be listed on NSE International Exchange and India International Exchange, marking a historic first IPO from the financial services hub.

NHAI-backed Raajmarg InvIT to launch ₹6,000-crore IPO tomorrow

Our Bureau
New Delhi

To monetise operational highway assets of the National Highways Authority of India, Raajmarg Infra Investment Trust (InvIT) will launch its ₹6,000-crore IPO on Wednesday, with a price band of ₹99-100 per unit. The issue will close on March 13. The NHAI uses mechanisms such as InvITs and the toll-operate-transfer (ToT) model to lease operational toll roads to investors for upfront payments. Besides, this strategy reduces debt pressure while also attracting

The InvIT issue comes with a price band of ₹99-100 per unit

long-term institutional investment into the road sector, enabling faster infrastructure expansion.

ROAD ASSETS The InvIT will hold five toll road assets across Jharkhand, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu and Karnataka under the ToT model. Investors can bid for a minimum of 150 units. The units are proposed to be listed on the National Stock Ex-

change of India and BSE. According to an InvIT official, the net proceeds from the issue are proposed to be utilised for infusion of debt and equity into the project special purpose vehicle (SPV), which will use the funds to pay the concession value of the InvIT assets to the NHAI, besides meeting general purposes. Up to 75 per cent of the net issue will be available for allocation to institutional investors, while not less than 25 per cent for non-institutional investors. The EPFO will be investing ₹1,000 crore, while SBI Life Insurance will pump in ₹260 crore in the InvIT.

Municipal bonds can strengthen urban infra funding, says Fadnavis

Our Bureau
Pune

Municipal corporations should increasingly raise funds from capital markets through municipal bonds to finance urban infrastructure projects, Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said, noting that such instruments can provide cities with a sustainable source of development funding. Speaking at the National Stock Exchange (NSE) in the Bandra-Kurla Complex during the listing of the Nashik Municipal Corporation's green bond on Monday, Fadnavis said urban local bodies should explore capital markets to mobilise resources for public infrastructure rather than relying solely on traditional government funding.

SETTING EXAMPLE He said the Nashik civic body had set an example by entering the capital market through municipal bond issuances and demonstrating how cities can tap investors to finance public infrastruc-



SUSTAINABLE GROWTH. Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis during the listing of the Nashik Municipal Corporation's green bond on Monday

ture projects. The Chief Minister noted that the Central government had introduced schemes to encourage municipal bond issuances. Initially, approval was given for municipal bodies to raise up to ₹200 crore through such bonds. Following the success of the initiative, the Union Budget increased the limit to ₹1,000 crore, while incentive support under the scheme has been raised to ₹200 crore. According to Fadnavis, funds mobilised through municipal bonds can support critical civic infrastructure such as water supply networks and urban development projects. He said the money raised through the

Nashik bond issue will be used for water supply projects aimed at reducing leakage in the city's distribution network.

SMALL CIVIC BODIES He suggested that smaller municipal corporations could collectively issue bonds worth about ₹1,000 crore in the capital market so that they too can benefit from the Centre's incentives and strengthen funding for urban infrastructure. Fadnavis called for the creation of innovative funding mechanisms by municipal bodies, saying these could improve the financial capacity of cities and accelerate urban development.

Sundaram Alternates launches hybrid fund with ₹1,500 crore target

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai



Karthik Athreya, MD, Sundaram Alternates

Sundaram Alternates (SA) is launching AlphaBet-Series I, a crossover investment product designed to combine the high-conviction equity investing with structural downside mitigation through secured private credit investments. The strategy aims to raise ₹1,500 crore, with a green shoe option of ₹500 crore. It will be structured to generate long-term capital appreciation from equities while incorporating a complementary secured credit portion for income visibility and portfolio. The fund will be targeting 18-20 per cent deal-level returns with portfolio-level investor returns expected in

the mid-teens range. 51-60 per cent of the portfolio would comprise of solid bets around equity in a 'flexicap' strategy with weightages between large, mid and small caps. The remaining would be private credit bets out of their own private credit platform, where SA has done close to \$1 billion worth transactions. Karthik Athreya, Managing Director, Sundaram Al-

ternates, told *businessline* that goal is to offer a product where investors take select equity exposures, which are research-driven with three to four year potential to make serious alpha and at the same time mitigate the volatility with a private credit strategy where SA has had a solid track record. "The product has actually come out of a feedback from our own large investors, family offices, etc., who want this sort of a mix," he said. Following the recent correction in the mid and small cap segments, Sundaram Alternates believes several fundamentally strong companies are now available at more attractive valuations. AlphaBet is designed to capitalise on these opportunities through a disciplined equity selection framework.

BROKER'S CALL.

Motilal Oswal

NIPPON AMC (BUY) Target: ₹1,040 CMP: ₹834.20 Nippon Life India AMC (NAM India) continues to deliver industry-leading market share gains, with MF quarterly average asset under management of ₹7 lakh crore (+23 per cent y-o-y) and overall share at a five-year high of 8.7 per cent. It is underpinned by steady net inflows, robust SIP momentum, and a favourable equity mix (47 per cent in Dec'25), driving the highest FY26YTD equity share accretion in the industry to 7.1 per cent (+11bp y-o-y). NAM India reported stable blended yields of 37bp in 3Q (equity: 53bp) despite rising passive contribution, supported by a healthy equity mix and traction in high-yielding commodity ETFs. Management continues to guide for an annual compression of 1-2bp due to telescopic pricing, to be offset by diversified retail flows, SIP growth, and product innovation. The company is scaling up its alternatives, Gift City, and offshore platforms, with cumulative AIF commitments of ₹892 crore, Gift City AUM of ₹370 crore, and offshore AUM of ₹18,000 crore, positioning these verticals as incremental growth drivers beyond the core MF franchise amid rising institutional and global investor participation. We expect a CAGR of 16/17/18 per cent in revenue/EBITDA/core PAT over FY26-28E. We reiterate a Buy rating on the stock with a target price of ₹1,040, premised on 38x core FY28E earnings.

Emkay Global

INTERGLOBE AVIATION (BUY) Target: ₹6,300 CMP: ₹4,236.00 The ongoing US-Israel conflict with Iran has rendered significant portions of the Middle East (ME) airspace inaccessible, leading to widespread flight cancellations and rerouting of services. This, combined with the existing closure of Pakistan's airspace, has disrupted Indigo's international operations (about 30 per cent ASK share), with flights to or through the ME (about 45 per cent of its international ASK) now affected. The company indicated that over 500 flights to the ME and select long-haul destinations (including Istanbul, Athens, Manchester, and Amsterdam) were cancelled between February 28 and March 3, due to airspace restrictions. With the conflict persisting, cancellations have been extended through Mach 4-6, with around 130-140 flights cancelled daily. At the same time, concerns around crude supply disruption following the closure of the Strait of Hormuz have driven up crude prices to >\$90/bbl. Jet fuel cracks have more than doubled to \$40-50/bbl, with some spot benchmarks showing up to USD80/bbl. If current trends persist, ATF prices for Apr-26E may rise by over 40 per cent, although the extent of pass-through by OMCs remains uncertain. While near-term visibility on the conflict remains limited, the strategic importance of ME energy flows to global markets could accelerate a resolution, in our view. We will revisit our estimates and TP as the fiscal comes to a close and on taking cues from next year's guidance. We retain Buy, with Dec-27E TP of ₹6,300.

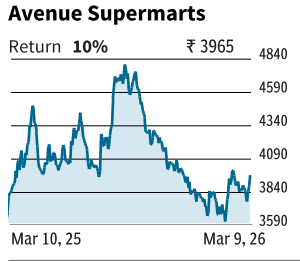
businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

TODAY'S PICK.

Avenue Supermarts (₹3,965.70): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

The short-term outlook is bullish for Avenue Supermarts. The stock has risen over 2 per cent on Monday when the broader markets were beaten down badly. This rise has taken the stock well above ₹3,920, an intermediate resistance. Barring the short-lived fall last week, the stock has been getting good support from the 55-Day Moving Average (DMA). This 55-DMA support is currently at ₹3,804. Cluster of supports are there in the ₹3,900-₹3,800 region. Avenue Supermarts share price can rise to ₹4,150 from here. Traders can buy Avenue Supermarts shares now at ₹3,965. Accumulate on dips at



₹3,910. Keep the stop-loss at ₹3,840. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹3,990 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹4,030. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹4,045 and ₹4,090 when the price touches ₹4,080 and ₹4,120 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹4,135.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

24092» Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
24000	23750	24280	24450	Go short on a reversal from 24280 with a stop-loss at 24320

₹839» HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
833	822	844	850	Go long only above 844. Stop-loss can be kept at 841

₹1316» Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1300	1280	1325	1345	Take fresh longs above 1325 with a stop-loss at 1320

₹305» ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
303	300	308	311	Go long on a rise at 307. Keep the stop-loss at 309

₹270» ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
266	263	273	276	Go short now and at 272. Stop-loss can be placed at 274

₹1418» Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1400	1380	1440	1460	Go long now and at 1405. Keep the stop-loss at 1395

₹1101» SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1080	1060	1120	1135	Wait for a rise. Go short at 1115 with a stop-loss at 1125

₹2528» TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2510	2490	2535	2560	Go long on a break above 2535. Keep the stop-loss at 2525

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers ▼ 422.40 pts.					
	Close(t)	Pts	PE	WN(t)	
Reliance Ind	1424.00	28.44	19.71	8.78	
Infosys	1315.00	5.07	19.04	4.21	
Wipro	138.75	2.10	15.63	0.52	
Sun Pharma	1887.40	1.86	39.59	1.75	
Apollo Hosp	7779.00	1.23	59.95	0.73	
Tech Mahindra	1336.30	0.64	28.52	0.77	
Cipla	1325.00	0.47	23.61	0.68	
HCL Tech	1358.60	0.44	22.38	1.31	
Max Healthcare	1041.50	-0.08	71.39	0.71	
Coal India	437.55	-1.39	9.66	0.39	
Trent Ltd.	3689.40	-1.63	80.97	0.75	
TataConsumerProduct	1102.50	-2.03	74.14	0.66	
Dr Reddys Lab	1287.00	-2.25	19.45	0.72	
Adani Enter	1999.20	-2.33	16.33	0.48	
Bharti Airtel	1866.70	-2.51	28.73	0.75	
NestleIndia	1235.80	-2.61	73.06	0.81	
SBI Life	1912.50	-2.87	77.36	0.78	
Grasim Ind	2681.20	-3.12	19.26	0.94	
Bajaj Finserv	1841.50	-3.44	15.33	0.96	
HDFC Life	653.75	-3.49	74.62	0.64	
PowerGrid Corp	295.20	-3.92	17.69	1.22	
Hindalco	945.35	-4.30	13.21	1.25	
NTPC	376.35	-4.32	14.69	1.83	
Eternal Ltd.	229.56	-4.74	959.02	1.51	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	323.25	-5.11	91.94	0.70	
Asian Paints	2220.80	-5.82	54.48	0.92	
Hind Unilever	2194.60	-6.05	51.28	1.78	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	987.20	-6.24	20.30	1.26	
TCS	2527.40	-6.77	19.07	2.36	
ONGC	270.90	-6.95	7.58	0.96	
Bajaj Finance	938.05	-7.08	31.85	2.27	
Titan	4159.20	-7.73	77.48	1.57	
ITC	306.00	-7.82	18.52	2.69	
IntiglobeAvi	4236.70	-8.30	51.01	0.87	
JSW Steel	1192.60	-8.47	37.55	1.02	
Tata Motors PV	332.00	-8.62	45.15	0.83	
Bharat Elec	457.35	-8.72	56.07	1.50	
Adani Ports	1423.30	-9.10	26.20	0.96	
Bajaj Auto	9383.00	-10.53	29.49	0.95	
Eicher Motors	7266.00	-10.70	37.20	0.91	
Tata Steel	1191.01	-13.51	26.14	1.44	
UltraTech Cement	1178.90	-13.97	43.75	1.23	
Axis Bank	1288.30	-17.29	15.14	3.37	
Maruti Suzuki	13508.00	-18.74	28.44	1.62	
Kotak Bank	386.35	-21.70	20.44	2.59	
L&T	3842.10	-27.75	27.85	4.12	
M&M	3187.60	-28.38	23.45	2.60	
State Bank	1098.50	-40.50	11.72	4.16	
ICICI Bank	1278.40	-54.81	16.15	3.15	
HDFC Bank	840.70	-54.87	16.70	11.74	
Pts: Impact on index movement					

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▼ 1,406.00 pts.
	Close(t)	Pts	PE	WN(t)	
AvenueSuper	3966.20	39.94	90.11	2.65	
Torrent Pharma	4373.70	7.04	65.15	2.08	
Lotimindtree	4317.20	7.01	27.10	1.82	
icici Lombard Gic	1889.70	6.83	34.41	2.08	
Adani Power	139.11	1.42	23.74	2.49	
Divis Lab	6330.00	0.38	67.79	3.65	
Macrotech Developers	888.85	-0.34	26.53	1.14	
Info Edge I	979.30	-0.93	37.69	1.73	
ZydusIntellisciences	908.85	-3.15	18.19	1.03	
Bajaj Housing Finance	82.30	-3.48	27.88	0.35	
AdaniGreenenergy	554.15	-3.91	46.15	1.19	
Hyundai Motor India	2084.20	-4.28	29.25	1.35	
DIF	574.95	-5.00	32.14	1.67	
Siemens Energy India	2883.20	-9.92	86.92	1.16	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	97.57	-10.19	18.20	0.79	
Siemens	3228.90	-10.81	72.52	1.30	
Lic	805.40	-11.26	9.61	0.81	
Adani Energy Solutions	981.40	-11.55	49.46	1.55	
Abb India	5982.50	-12.51	75.17	1.42	
Solar Industries	14977.00	-12.79	88.77	1.66	
Tata Power	372.90	-13.10	23.79	2.84	
Havells	1331.40	-13.47	56.32	1.52	
Jsw Energy	478.90	-14.97	32.15	1.17	
Hindus Zinc	575.00	-15.41	20.59	1.13	
HindustanAeronautics	3989.90	-19.24	29.99	3.44	
Mazgaon Dock	2387.00	-19.35	40.01	0.82	
Ambuja Cements	451.95	-27.08	22.70	1.25	
United Spirits	1355.80	-30.13	57.33	1.82	
Indian Hotels Co.	611.70	-32.02	40.23	2.44	
Britannia Ind	5890.00	-32.81	58.71	3.15	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	697.55	-36.88	99.01	2.17	
Bajaj Holdings	10250.00	-40.27	12.3		
Bank Of Orissa	288.05	-40.63	7.58	2.43	
Yash Beverages	427.75	-40.65	48.83	2.02	
Jindal Steel	1144.10	-40.70	57.89	1.94	
Gordal Consumer	1080.30	-43.82	60.68	1.97	
Punjab Natk Bank	1150.7	-43.86	7.40	1.95	
Pilditind	1386.40	-44.16	60.97	1.95	
Bosch	3160.00	-45.16	33.88	1.24	
Shree Cement	2359.00	-51.56	47.33	1.43	
Cholamandalam	544.68	-54.46	11.38	1.82	
Cholamandalam&Fin	1583.00	-54.94	27.56	2.04	
Rural Elec	324.40	-55.27	49.95	1.84	
Vedanta	709.40	-59.04	16.74	5.46	
Canara Bank	139.91	-61.30	6.89	2.14	
Samvardhanothersinternat	117.98	-63.83	34.22	2.38	
Power Finance	392.80	-65.75	7.88	2.60	
Indian Oilcorp	161.22	-83.63	6.17	2.74	
Tata Steel Mtp	367.80	-110.03	56.44	3.87	
Bpel	331.15	-125.61	5.84	2.91	

Pts: Impact on index movement

QUICKLY.

Flipkart completes
domicile shift to India



Bengaluru: Flipkart has completed its reverse flip, shifting its domicile back to India from Singapore, paving the way for the Walmart-owned firm to move ahead with its plans to list on the Indian stock exchanges. The company has begun early discussions with merchant bankers as it prepares for a potential initial public offering (IPO) and is aiming to file its draft prospectus later this year, according to people familiar with the development. Flipkart moved its holding structure to Singapore in 2011. At the time, several Indian start-ups adopted overseas domiciles to tap global capital more easily under simpler regulatory regimes in markets such as Singapore and the US.

Federal Bank ups focus
on wealth management



Federal Bank has announced the launch of its wealth management platform and the inauguration of its first Wealth Hub, marking the next phase of the bank's strategic expansion in the wealth management business. The bank will establish dedicated Wealth Hubs across key locations. These specialised centres will provide clients with a private, premium environment to engage with relationship managers and portfolio counsellors, review investment strategies, and access research insights across asset classes through both in-person and virtual consultations, said a press release.

ABB plans to invest \$75 m in India to boost manufacturing and R&D

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Switzerland-headquartered automation machinery manufacturer ABB said it will invest about \$75 million in India in 2026 to expand manufacturing capacity and research and development facilities across several locations.

The investment follows spending of more than \$35 million in 2025. It forms part of the company's strategy to expand local manufacturing and research capabilities in the country.

The company said about 85 per cent of its products sold in India are manufactured locally.

The investment will support operations in electrification, motion and automation.

It will also support sectors such as renewable energy, metro rail, data centres and power infrastructure.

300 JOBS

About 300 jobs in engineering, operations and research are expected to be created.

"This investment in India is an important part of our strategy to support infrastructure build-out and growth in one of our fastest growing markets," said Morten Wierod, Chief Executive Officer, ABB.

He said the expanded facility will meet demand driven by India's energy transition, upgrades to the power grid, growth in data centres, and expansion of metro and high-speed rail networks.

In Bengaluru, ABB will invest \$14 million at its Nelamangala campus to expand production and launch

Private banks made ₹11,000 cr in FY23-25 by penalising a/cs sans minimum balance

THE BREAKUP. PSBs raked in ₹8,000 cr; HDFC Bank ₹3,800 cr; Axis Bank ₹2,700 cr and ICICI Bank ₹1,200 cr

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Private sector banks collected around ₹11,000 crore in three years (fiscal year 2022-23 to fiscal year 2024-25) as compared to ₹8,000 crore collected by public sector banks on account of non-maintenance of minimum monthly average balance (MAB), data provided by the Finance Ministry in the Lok Sabha on Monday showed.

According to data in the written response of Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, HDFC Bank emerged as the top earner with over ₹3,800 crore, followed by Axis Bank and ICICI Bank with over ₹2,700 crore and ₹1,200 crore, respectively.

Among the public sector banks, PNB was on top in terms of the total amount collected during the three years with over ₹1,500 crore followed by Bank of Baroda (over ₹1,200 crore) and Indian bank (over 1,100 crore).

India's largest bank, State Bank of India, completely waived off penal charges for

not maintaining minimum balance in saving accounts since March 2020. Following that, many other public sector bank such as the Punjab National Bank and Canara Bank removed such charges last year.

However, they do have changes for current account. At the same time, private sector banks are still charging for not maintaining minimum balance.

For example, HDFC Bank stipulates average monthly balance for metro and urban branches at ₹10,000 or FD of ₹1 lakh for minimum 1 year 1 day period; in case of semi urban, it is ₹5,000 or FD of ₹50,000 for minimum 1 year 1 day period and in rural areas, it is ₹2,500 or FD of ₹25,000 for minimum 1 year 1 day period. Non-maintenance charge would be 6 per cent of the shortfall from the average balance requirement or ₹600, whichever is lower.

PMJDY ACCOUNTS

Meanwhile, in her reply, Sitharaman said banks offer zero-balance savings ac-



Amount collected by banks for not maintaining minimum balance

Public sector				Private sector			
2022-23	2023-24	2024-25		2022-23	2023-24	2024-25	
All 12	2,408	2,907	2,776	All 21	3,172	3,620	4,199
Top earners				Top earners			
Indian Bank	295	368	503	HDFC Bank	1,036	1,317	1,519
Bank of Baroda	387	443	441	Axis Bank	878	826	1,001
PNB	486	674	418	ICICI	400	433	391
SBI	211	303	418	Kotak Mahindra	192	261	254
Canara Bank	391	359	278	Yes Bank	60	70	120

counts facility, better known as basic savings bank deposit accounts (BSBDAs), including the accounts opened under the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY). These accounts do not require maintenance of any minimum balance. Accordingly, "approximately 72

crore BSBDAs, including, PMJDY accounts are not subject to any penal charges for non-maintenance of minimum balance," she said.

However, for accounts other than BSBDAs including PMJDY accounts, banks may levy charges for non-maintenance of minimum

monthly average balance (MAB) in accordance with their board-approved policies and the extant instructions of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), she said.

TOTAL INCOME

Further, she added that an amount of over ₹8,000 crore collected over the last three financial years constitutes approximately 0.23 per cent of the total income of public sector banks during the same period, "indicating that such charges form only a very small proportion of banks' income and are primarily aligned with the cost of providing banking services rather than revenue generation through penalties."

She also mentioned that in cases of non-maintenance of the agreed minimum balance in bank accounts, banks have been advised by the RBI to notify customers through SMS, email, letter or appropriate means. Customers are generally provided time to restore the required minimum balance before penal charges are applied as per extant regulatory guidelines.

MM Forgings to deploy 150 robots amid manpower shortage

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

MM Forgings, the Chennai-based auto component manufacturer, plans to deploy 100-150 robots across its facilities to address manpower shortages and rising labour costs, according to CMD Vidyashankar Krishnan.

Speaking at the Auto Ancillaries' Virtual Investor Conference, Krishnan said automation is becoming necessary as labour costs continue to climb.

"Manpower costs are rising rapidly, and one of the ways to mitigate them is to look at productivity everywhere and across the board," he added.

Each robot can replace

roughly 3 per cent of the manpower, he noted, adding that the manufacturing sector faces stiff competition for workers from the services industry.

"We say India has a huge opportunity, but we also have a huge competition from the same manpower from the services industry. Somebody working as a janitor in a mall does not have to work as hard or in as harsh an environment as in a forge shop," he said.

CAPEX PLAN

Krishnan said the company plans to invest about ₹160 crore in capital expenditure next fiscal. The investment will go towards completing the 16,500 tonne press, fin-



Vidyashankar Krishnan, CMD, MM Forgings

ishing the installation of the 4,000 tonne press, and adding capacity on the machining side.

"If there are new customer interests and cash availability, then the capex could increase up to ₹200

crore," he added. Krishnan said the company has seen a sharp decline in revenue from the US market, which has affected overall growth.

US REVENUE

"As far as the US is concerned, the company has lost almost 10 per cent of revenue. While we have grown in other geographies, including India, we have not grown overall only because the US market has tanked," he said.

The US share in MM Forgings' revenue has dropped from about 16-17 per cent earlier to around 9 per cent now, he added.

"That's a huge reduction we have had to face. Otherwise, we would have seen some growth this year as

well," he said. Despite the setback in the US, Krishnan said demand conditions remain favourable.

GEOPOLITICAL WOES

"The US market is very strong and the Indian truck market is doing well. Subject to similar macroeconomic conditions, particularly geopolitical tensions not throwing a spanner in the works, the company should be able to easily achieve 20 per cent growth next year," he said.

"We have the parts and the orders for that," he added.

He noted that the company had consistently invested nearly ₹1,000 crore over the past five years, which is expected to provide strong growth tailwinds.

Versuni to double air fryer output to 2 m units

Our Bureau
Chennai

Versuni, the Netherlands-based home appliance firm (formerly known as Philips Domestic Appliances), will double its annual air fryer production at its Ahmedabad plant to two million. The expansion will happen in a

month, Gulbahar Taurani, Managing Director & CEO, Versuni India, told newsmen on Monday at the company's plant on the outskirts of Chennai.

NEW FACILITY

Versuni India has launched a manufacturing facility in Chennai as part of a major expansion of its existing

manufacturing operations.

This is to strengthen local production capabilities across high-growth appliance categories, while reinforcing its long-term commitment to manufacturing in India. The facility will enhance Versuni's production capacity for key categories including air fryers, air purifiers and kitchen appliances,

while supporting the company's broader localisation strategy and improving supply chain efficiency for the Indian market.

"The demand for air fryers in India is exploding. The company started manufacturing air fryers in 2024 with 5 lakh units a year; this will increase by four times to 20 lakh in two years," he said.

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Tender Ref: Dbees/RM/2024-27 Publication Date: 10/03/26
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NO. ITEM DESCRIPTION (GRADE/TYPE) TOTAL QUANTITY (MT)
1. Raw Rice Jaya Broken 155 MT
2. White Onions 313 MT
3. Raw Chili 5331 49 MT
4. Rava roasted 46 MT
5. Chembur Rice 17 MT
6. Raw Wheat 12 MT
7. Foxtail Millet 8 MT
8. Raw Rice IR64 White 103.2 MT
9. Coriander Seed 128 MT
10. Turmeric Finger (Whole) 16 MT
11. Raw Chilly DDO 17 MT
12. Raw Chilly 5331 17 MT
13. Raw Chilly DABBI 16 MT
14. Raw Chilly KOL 60 MT
15. Wheat Flour 437 MT
16. Salt 7 MT
17. Sunflower Oil 26 MT
18. Garlic Brine 4.5 MT
19. Lemon Brine 6 MT
20. Mango Brine 11 MT
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TATA mutual fund

NOTICE

Unitholders are hereby informed about the declaration of Income Distribution cum capital withdrawal under the Periodic Payout/Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum capital withdrawal option (IDCW Periodic-Payout/Reinvestment) and under the Payout of Income Distribution cum capital withdrawal option (IDCW-Payout) of the following schemes. The record date for the same is 12 March, 2026.

Schemes - Plan / Option Name	Gross income distribution cum capital withdrawal amount per unit (Rs.) **	Face value per unit (₹)	NAV (₹) as on 06 Mar, 26
Tata Aggressive Hybrid Fund - Direct Plan Periodic IDCW	10.58	10.00	106.1176
Tata Aggressive Hybrid Fund - Regular Plan Periodic IDCW	10.58	10.00	87.3869
Tata ELSS Fund - Direct Plan - IDCW	8.00	10.00	229.0208
Tata ELSS Fund - Regular Plan - IDCW	8.00	10.00	99.0006

Pursuant to payment of Income Distribution cum capital withdrawal, the NAV of the scheme would fall to the extent of the payout & statutory levy (if applicable).

Unitholders kindly note that amounts are distributed out of investors capital (i.e., Equalisation Reserve), which is part of sale price of the unit that represents realized gains.

** Payment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is subject to Tax deducted at source (TDS) at applicable rates and other statutory levies if any. Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is subject to availability & adequacy of distributable surplus on the record date.

All unitholders holding units under the above-mentioned option of the scheme as at close of business hours, on the record date shall be eligible for dividend.

Considering the volatile nature of markets, the Trustees reserves the right to restrict the quantum of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal upto the per unit distributable surplus available on the record date in case of fall in the market.

Applicable for units held in non-demat form: Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal will be paid to those Unitholders whose names appear in the Register of Unitholders under the Payout/Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option of the aforesaid plan as on record date. These payouts would be done to the last bank/address details updated in our records.

Applicable for units held in demat form: Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal will be paid to those Unitholders/Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories under the Payout/Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option of the aforesaid plan as on record date. These payouts would be done to the last bank/address details updated in Depository Participant(s) records.

Mutual Fund Investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

GM's ACDelco re-enters India to sell batteries and lubricants for automobiles

Our Bureau
New Delhi



US auto major General Motors' aftermarket automotive products brand, ACDelco has re-entered the Indian market through a licensing pact with Assurance International, which plans to invest ₹300 crore in a battery plant over next three years.

The company has already invested ₹180 crore in the lubricant plant at Hisar in Haryana with a capacity of one lakh litres per day.

The battery plant is also coming up in Hisar with a production capacity of 25,000 units per day, once it is fully operational.

The battery manufacturing operations will start from next month, the firm added.

"This is a licensing agreement within which we would be manufacturing, marketing and selling the product lines. Manufacturing will happen in technical collaboration with ACDelco where they will be overseeing the quality of the products alongside the quality standards, but marketing and sales will be with us. Manufacturing facilities are also with us," Mukesh Sharma, Chief Executive Officer, Assurance International Ltd, said.

PRODUCT LINE-UP

The initial product line-up of ACDelco in India includes automotive batteries and a range of high-performance

lubricants designed for passenger vehicles and commercial vehicles operating under Indian driving conditions, and in the future, it would add other products such as wipers and oil filters.

The company said localised manufacturing will help ensure competitive pricing while maintaining global quality standards associated with the ACDelco brand.

The products will be distributed through a multi-tier distribution network covering distributors, retailers and service workshops across key automotive markets in India.

"The relaunch of ACDelco automotive batteries and lubricants products in India through an official licensing arrangement is aligned with our global aftermarket brand strategy. Assurance International's operational capabilities and understanding of local market requirements provide a strong platform for the ACDelco brand in the country," Mahesh Ravindran, Country Lead - Commercial Operations, Chevrolet Sales India, said.

COCHIN INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LTD. TENDER NOTICE

CIAL/COMM/FSS/01 10/03/2026
Online Item rate E-tenders are invited from reputed agencies for the work mentioned below at Cochin International Airport.

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Estimate Amount	EMD	Completion Period
1	SITC of Fire Suppression System at CIAL.	₹2.75 Crore + GST	₹5.50 Lakhs	06 Months

Interested firms may register themselves on the online E-Tendering portal <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> and then download the Tender documents. For eligibility criteria and other details, visit our website www.cial.aero Sd/-, Managing Director

TATA TATA POWER (Contracts Department)

Jobobera Generation Plant, RAHARGORAH, JAMSHEDPUR-831016, Jharkhand

NOTICE INVITING EXPRESSION OF INTEREST

The Tata Power Company Limited invites expression of interest from eligible vendors for the package Name

S.No.	Tender Description	Ref No
1	Supply of Apron feeder spares at Tata Power Jobobera-Jamshedpur	CC26PSJUJO-16
2	Supply of Gland Packing and Gaskets	CC26BSJUJO-15
3	ARC for Support Service in Chemical Lab IEL PH#7-Jamshedpur	CC26RKJUJO-03

For details of pre-qualification requirements, bid security, purchasing of tender document etc., please visit Tender section of our website (URL: <https://www.tatapower.com/tender>). Eligible vendors willing to participate may submit their expression of interest along with the tender fee for issue of bid document latest by 22nd Mar'26.

ESAF GOLD AUCTION NOTICE

Notice is hereby given for the information of all concerned that Gold ornaments pledged with ESAF Small Finance Bank and not redeemed by borrowers, despite repeated reminders and notices, of our branches, are listed below. This will be auctioned as per the details given below:

DATE OF AUCTION: 19-03-2026 **TIME: 2pm to 5 pm**
AUCTION VENUE: Through e-Auction
AUCTION ADDRESS: <https://egold.auctiontiger.net>
Contact Number: 9099013705 / 6351896640

To register as bidder for the e-Auction with terms and conditions, and full details of e-Auction please visit the above site.

BRANCHES & LOAN ACCOUNT NUMBERS

CHENNAI - MOGAAPPAIR EAST: 75250000286622, 2490813, CHENNAI-PURASAWALKAM: 75250002338081, ANAMALAI: 75250002381608, ANNUR: 75250002432494, COIMBATORE TRICHY ROAD: 75250002250306, 2444021, KANJAPPALLY: 75250002651802, MASAGOUDENCHETTIAPALAYAM: 7525000229741, 2276396, 2469094, POLLACHI: 7525000277899, SINGANAILLUR (ONDIPUTHUR): 75250002301741, BHUVANAGIRI: 7525000214949, CUDALORE: 75250002470731, 2483686, PANRUTY: 7525000235726, 279693, BATLAGUNDA: 75250002264619, 2435168, 2491691, DINDIGUL: 7525000242029, PALANI: 7525000231764, REDDIRARCHATTIRAM: 7525000227993, 2266025, SANARPATTI: 75250002286097, 2315325, VEDASANDAM: 75250002278143, 2467757, 2492679, ANTHIYUR: 632500019361, 75250002460450, 2464523, ELAVAMALAI: 75250002290049, 2418171, 2462736, ERODE: 75250002459923, 2482498, GOPICHETTIAPALAYAM: 7525000217094, 238471, SATHYAMANGALAM: 63250001764533, 75250002342173, 2345237, 2368994, 2461898, 2461888, TRUKKOVILUR: 7525000197499, 0230958, 0232255, 0232605, 0243994, 2328150, 2366577, 2429390, ULUNDURPETTAI: 7525000211265, 2269430, 2468805, 2490583, KANCHIPURAM: 75250002423301, 2492929, KATTANKULATHUR: 75250002377236, 2426135, 2492569, MADHURANTAKAM: 63250002462586, ALANGULAM: 63250000194002, 75250002452005, PULIANKUDU: 7525000214639, 2283043, 2344219, 2378195, 2393455, UTHIRAMERUR: 75250002303357, 2347444, COLACHEL: 75250002329618, 2352344, 2373284, 2378095, 2394794, KULASEKARAM: 75250001946684, NAGERCOIL: 75250002263781, 2329928, 2444001, THAKKALAI: 75250002400485, 2433912, THIRUPPARAPPU: 75250002325345, 2387035, 2368904, THOOTHUR: 75250000557153, HOSUR: 75250002461588, MADURAI: 75250002285249, MAGAPATTINAM: 75250000195186, 2268472, 2267416, 2334458, 2345737, 2388375, 2400195, 2432864, 2460460, NAMAKKAL: 75250002414098, GUDALUR: 75250002468145, 2472347, KOTTAGIRI: 75250002472377, MANJOOR-SELAS: 75250002260116, OOTY: 7525000233883, PUDUKKOTTAI: 75250002354500, RAMANATHAPURAM: 75250002408280, SALEM: 7525000182237, 0280383, SIVANGANGA: 75250002462586, ALANGULAM: 63250000194002, 75250002452005, PULIANKUDU: 75250002412942, THANJAVUR: 75250002368184, ANDIPATTI: 75250002433132, BODINAYAKKUMARI: 75250002370189, 2419499, 3168303, CHINNAMANUR: 7525000272278, CUMBUM: 75250002342493, 2415616, 2491111, MOTTANUTHU: 75250002265247, 2265787, 2360099, 2362555, 2382946, POONALAIKUNTA: 75250002454362, UNJAMPATTY: 7525000262253, 2472117, MINUR: 63250001774194, 75250002269630, 2291067, 2298705, ARANI: 75250002312920, 2386249, 2402331, 2420546, CHEYAR: 7525000281971, 2294472, 2410935, THIRUVANMALAI: 75250002259689, 2426675, 2437255, THIRUVARUR: 75250002314826, 2390959, 2472977, KOVILPATTI: 75250002267014, 2267344, 2316563, 2476220, 2280322, SATHANKULAM: 75250002391629, TIRUCHIRAPPALLI: 75250002452295, AMBASANDURAM: 7525000243754, 2261475, 2439401, KANYAKUMARI: 75250002413430, PALAYAKKOTTAI-TIRUNELVELI: 75250002264319, DHARAPURAM: 75250002415916, 2439501, 2453884, 2423017, KANGAYAM: 6325000131602, 75250002445439, 2409611PETTAI: 75250002287013, 2410335, 2439621, TINDIVANAM: 7525000209449, 0236227, 2259519, VILUPPURAM: 75250001917839, 0189955, 0189957, 2434390, 2486985, 2449485, ARUPPUKOTTAI: 7525000265392, 0670899, MALLANKINARU: 75250002265817.

Customers who are interested to release the ornaments by paying the total due amount may do so, at the respective branches, on or two days before the date of the auction.

Bidders who wish to participate in the auction shall produce their KYC documents. GST No. is mandatory for registered firms/companies. Bidders shall deposit a sum of Rs.50,000 as EMD before participating in the auction.

Thirsur Sd/-
Date: 10-03-2026 Authorized Signatory

UTTAR PRADESH POWERING INDIA'S AI REVOLUTION

From Digital Governance to a \$1 Trillion Economic Vision

Artificial Intelligence is emerging as the defining force of the global economic transition. As data becomes the strategic asset of the new era, Uttar Pradesh is positioning itself at the centre of India's AI-led transformation.

Data is the foundation of the new economy and AI will become the 'New Oil'
- Yogi Adityanath, Chief Minister, U.P.

The State's policy direction reflects that conviction, integrating infrastructure, governance reform, industrial investment and human capital development into a coherent growth strategy.



Strengthening Digital Infrastructure

Uttar Pradesh has laid the groundwork for large-scale digital expansion through sustained public investment and policy reform.

8
Data Center Parks

900 MW
Target Capacity

₹ 30,000 cr.
Proposed Investment

₹ 21,000 cr.
Realised Investment

644 MW
Currently Operational

The State's data infrastructure is designed to operate on 24x7 carbon-free energy, aligning digital growth with sustainability commitments.

24x7 carbon-conscious digital infrastructure

From Reactive Administration to Predictive Governance

Leveraging Data, Technology and AI to Build Proactive, Future-Ready Governance in Uttar Pradesh

Governance in Uttar Pradesh is undergoing structural transformation. Moving beyond traditional "problem-solution" models, the State is building systems that anticipate challenges through data integration and real-time analytics. **Key institutional reforms include:** ■ Establishment of a State Data Authority ■ Integrated departmental databases ■ Strengthened digital authentication systems ■ Expanded citizen-centric digital service delivery. The emphasis is on proactive policy design, improved transparency and faster administrative response. By linking datasets across departments, the government aims to enable informed decision-making and measurable governance outcomes. As Chief Minister has observed, "Critical thinking in linking and meaningfully utilising data will be the true game changer."

Global Confidence in Uttar Pradesh

₹2.92 lakh crore worth MoUs signed

31 sectoral agreements

USD 25 billion AI-led data center investments

1 Gigawatt capacity by 2030

A landmark agreement signed at the World Economic Forum in Davos further reinforced the State's global positioning as an emerging technology and manufacturing hub.

These partnerships are expected to catalyse high-skilled employment, strengthen integrated hardware, software ecosystems and enhance export competitiveness.



MoU signed at World Economic Forum, Davos

Strategic Impact and Sustainable Growth

- The initiative is expected to attract substantial foreign direct investment and enhance the State's global competitiveness.
- It is likely to generate significant high-skilled employment across technology and allied sectors.
- It seeks to strengthen the integrated ecosystem spanning hardware, software, and advanced cooling infrastructure.
- It envisages round-the-clock operations powered by carbon-free energy, reinforcing sustainable growth.

Engagements at the World Economic Forum in Davos have reinforced investor confidence in the state's digital and infrastructure roadmap.

Building a Future-Ready Digital Workforce



AI Mission

- ₹225 crore allocation
- AI Labs in 49 ITIs
- 65 Data & AI Labs planned



Tech Yuva Samarth Yuva

- 25 lakh youth to be trained
- AI, AR, VR, XR exposure
- ₹100 crore provision



AI Pragya

- AI literacy for 10 lakh citizens
- Industry collaboration
- Skill alignment with industry needs

Uttar Pradesh's emphasis on building a future-ready workforce marks a significant policy shift from mere infrastructure creation to human capital development. Through the 'Tech Yuva-Samarth Yuva' initiative, 25 lakh youth are to be trained in Artificial Intelligence, AR, VR and other emerging technologies, aligning skills with industry demand. The establishment of AI labs in 49 ITIs and the expansion of data and AI labs across the state reflect a structured attempt to integrate vocational education with frontier technologies. Such measures aim to ensure that young people are not just degree holders, but skilled participants in a rapidly evolving digital economy.

Technology as a Growth Multiplier

With sustained investment in infrastructure, skilling and digital governance, Uttar Pradesh is aligning technology adoption with long-term economic expansion and institutional reform. According to state budget allocations for 2025-26, IT and electronics expenditure has been significantly enhanced to support this transition.

Driving industrial investment, job creation, startup ecosystem, transparency and digital inclusion

When technology is guided by compassion, development becomes truly inclusive. - Yogi Adityanath, Chief Minister, U.P.

Digital Infrastructure • Skilled Youth • Transparent Governance
Uttar Pradesh's Roadmap to a Trillion-Dollar Economy

QUICKLY.

Tech Mahindra refutes rumours of huge layoffs



Mumbai: Tech Mahindra on Monday denied social media rumours of an upcoming layoff of up to 30,000 employees. “The company has received calls and has noted certain social media posts regarding a market rumour of a potential significant reduction in headcount. The company on its own accord considers it necessary to clarify to the stock exchanges that no such proposal is under consideration and categorically denies any such market rumours,” said Tech Mahindra in an exchange filing. **OUR BUREAU**

Truhome Finance files DRHP for ₹3,000 cr IPO



Mumbai: Truhome Finance Ltd, formerly known as Shriram Housing Finance Ltd, has filed its draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) with market regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India for a ₹3,000 crore initial public offer. The Warburg Pincus backed housing finance company's IPO comprises a fresh issue of equity shares of face value ₹10 each aggregating up to ₹1,500 crore and an offer for sale of equity shares (by promoter selling shareholder Mango Crest Investment Ltd) of face value ₹10 each aggregating up to ₹1,500 crore. **OUR BUREAU**

‘Social media ban falls within national jurisdiction, will look at State laws’

CRUCIAL REVIEW. Any State-level ban must be examined for legislative competence: MeitY Secretary S Krishnan

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Topics like social media fall within the national jurisdiction and any related ban must be examined for legislative competence, said S Krishnan, Secretary, Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), addressing queries on the social media bans in some States. Speaking on the sidelines of the 85th Internet Corporation for Assigned Names and Numbers (ICANN) Community Forum, Krishnan said, “We have not yet seen what the legislation is. We

will have to see whether it falls within the competence of the respective State government and we will have to see how exactly the legislative competence works.” The Secretary spoke in response to media queries on the social media ban for children proposed by Karnataka (for under-16s) and Andhra Pradesh (under-13s). **SOCIAL MEDIA CURBS** During the India AI Summit, Union IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw had spoken about an age-based social media restriction. Asked whether the government will shorten the timeline for India’s data pro-



MeitY Secretary S Krishnan

tection compliance from 18 months to 12, Krishnan said the government is awaiting inputs from stakeholders. “We have been consulting

with the industry on this aspect. We are awaiting their inputs and once we get them, we will take a final call,” he said.

Stressing that India must get involved in Internet governance, Krishnan spoke about challenges such as malicious traffic on the Internet, attempts to change domain names and intellectual property. He called for universal acceptance of domain names in regional languages like भारत and .in, which has crossed over 4 million registered users, as per NIXI or the National Internet Exchange of India. Regarding regional domains, Sushil Pal, Joint Secretary, MeitY, said the registry plans to ensure double-digit growth by carrying out a massive outreach and marketing strategy.



daCmbs/AB/1087

Indonesia in initial deal to acquire BrahMos missiles

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Indonesia has entered into an initial agreement with India to acquire BrahMos supersonic missiles, the second country after the Philippines to increase their air defence capabilities, senior Defence Ministry sources said.

“Final contract yet to be signed but an initial agreement is there with Indonesia,” the sources added. India, however, is yet to announce the missile contract while Indonesian Defence Ministry spokesperson Rico Ricardo Sirait told *Reuters* that the two countries have entered into a deal “part of the modernisation of military hardware and defence capabilities, especially in the maritime sector.” **VALUE NOT KNOWN** The spokesperson declined to give value of the deal of BrahMos missiles, jointly produced with Russia. Both New Delhi and Jakarta have been negotiating for more than three years. *businessline* on Monday reported that General Romeo S Brawner Jr, Chief of Staff of



the Armed Forces of Philippines, had expressed satisfaction over the performance of BrahMos missiles, which had demonstrated precision guided strikes during Operation Sindoor. General Romeo S Brawner Jr, who was here to participate in Raisina Dialogue 2026, also revealed that Indonesia had entered into a contract for the acquisition of BrahMos missiles. “The Philippines was the first country to buy the BrahMos missile systems. Now, Indonesia has bought the same system. I can say that we’re happy with our purchase, and hopefully we can do more business with India,” said General Romeo S Brawner Jr. It is learnt that Vietnam is also at an advanced stage of acquiring the missiles, which travels at a speed of 2.8 Mach.

Iran refuses to relent as Khamenei’s son made leader

Bloomberg

Iran chose Mojtaba Khamenei, the hardline son of the assassinated Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, as its new supreme leader, signalling that Tehran won’t back down in a war now raging across West Asia and causing a surge in energy prices. The choice was quickly criticised by US President Donald Trump, who is under mounting pressure as oil prices rise to near four-year highs and fears grow of a new inflation crisis. **EFFECTIVE CLOSURE** The effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz has forced Saudi Arabia, the world’s biggest oil exporter, to reduce production, according to a person familiar with the matter. That follows similar



moves by the UAE, Kuwait and Iraq. Trump, whose administration is already facing criticism after US petrol pump prices jumped last week, called \$100 oil a “small price to pay” and said the cost “will drop rapidly when the destruction of the Iran nuclear threat is over”. The war — now in its

second week — shows no sign of easing off. The US and Israel continued to strike Iran, which is still attacking Israel and Arab Gulf states regularly with drones and missiles. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) intercepted a ballistic missile fired from Iran toward Turkey on Monday, the second such incident, raising the risk the military alliance could be drawn more directly into the conflict. Trump told *Fox News* he is “not happy” with Iran’s pick. Khamenei was a favourite to be selected, though there were several other candidates in the running, some of who might have been more amenable to the US. **1ST DEPARTURE ORDER** On Monday, the US ordered American non-essential diplomats in Saudi Arabia to

leave the country, citing safety risks. The move marks Washington’s first “ordered departure” since the war began. It follows a US service member dying overnight after being wounded in an attack on US troops in Saudi Arabia on March 1. That brought the US death toll in the war to seven.

G7 to release oil reserves if needed

Bloomberg

The Group of Seven Finance Ministers said they were ready to take any steps needed to support global energy supply, including releasing strategic oil reserves. “We will continue to closely monitor the situation and developments in the energy

markets and will meet as needed to exchange information and to coordinate within the G-7 and with international partners,” the Group said. G-7 Finance Ministers, along with heads of the International Monetary Fund, World Bank Group, among others held a virtual meeting on Monday to discuss the West Asian conflict.

Standard Chartered reshaping retail push in India to prioritise wealthy customers

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Standard Chartered is undertaking a strategic redrawing of its retail banking strategy in India in the last few years to focus more on establishing multi-product relationships with affluent clients with needs for cross-border financial activity, rather than the mass retail segment, said the chief of its wealth and retail banking unit. India’s first International Financial Services Centre GIFT City will also play a key role in this endeavour. “We can’t be everything to everybody. We want to focus on our core strength, which is international, cross-border, and affluent. In the wealth and retail banking (WRB) business, we’re increasingly pivoting to help clients grow and protect their wealth, both domestic-



Judy Hsu, CEO, Wealth and Retail Banking, Standard Chartered

ally and overseas,” Judy Hsu, CEO, Wealth and Retail Banking, Standard Chartered, said in an exclusive interaction with *businessline*. **GROWING SEGMENT** In India, we have been historically focused more on lending and regular retail products, but we have now taken steps to reach the growing segment of India’s

wealthy, she added. With this pivot, Standard Chartered joins a line of foreign banks who have been steadily cutting back routine retail transaction banking in India over the last few years. In WRB, the bank has a mix of affluent Indians looking to grow their wealth domestically and also those who have business or other investments (typically real estate) outside India and lean on the bank’s portfolio of products for these. Standard Chartered has more than a million clients in India for its wealth and retail banking with more than 200,000 in the affluent category. The bank has added 11 ‘affluent centres’ within its branch network and plans to continue investing in re-designing these to offer advisory to the wealthy complementing the digital channels. “We are also looking at us-

ing GIFT City to offer more access to international products and support our wealth business,” Hsu said. **REGULATORY CLARITY** The bank has been engaging with specialists since September to get regulatory clarity and plan how they can structure the wealth management proposition from GIFT City. “We should have more to share by later this year, we are moving fast,” she added. In October last year, the banking major announced it is launching US dollar clearance from the financial centre. ‘Global Indians’ and ‘Global Chinese’ are among key drivers of Standard Chartered’s WRB business. Hsu noted that India’s high network individuals (HNIs) are quite savvy in their investment avenues, and more digitally native compared to global peers.

Crypto SIPs rise despite price corrections

Rohan Das
Chennai

Though major crypto currencies have seen significant price corrections over the last few months, Indian crypto exchanges are reporting an increase in crypto systematic investment plans (SIPs). According to data made available to *businessline*, top crypto exchanges have witnessed strong year-on-year growth in total SIPs towards currencies such as Bitcoin and Ethereum during the October 2025-January 2026 period as compared to the same period last year. For instance, Mudrex saw a significant acceleration, with the number of new SIPs initiated between October 2025 to January 2026 being around 70 per cent higher when compared to the same period last year. Similarly, Coinswitch, which has a user base of about 2.5 crore, witnessed a



MARKET VOLATILITY. The increase in SIPs can be attributed to both investors trying to capitalise on the dips and also a change in perception towards crypto as an asset

25 per cent jump while CoinDCX witnessed an even sharper growth from 50,000 to 1,74,000 SIPs initiated, a 3X year-on-year increase.

BUYING THE DIP These surges have come despite prominent crypto currencies seeing sharp drops in their prices. Bitcoin, which was trading upwards of \$120,000 in October, closed at around \$78,635 in January 2026. Similarly, Ethereum which reached a high of \$4,758 in October closed at \$2,449 in January 2026.

Ashish Singhal, Co-founder, CoinSwitch, said he believes that the increase in SIPs can be attributed to both investors trying to capitalise on the dips and also a change in perception towards crypto as an asset. “While price corrections do encourage some opportunistic buying, higher SIP adoption indicates long-term participation reflecting that crypto as an asset is maturing and becoming part of the regular investment planning,” he said. Edul Patel, CEO of

Mudrex echoed this, suggesting that a larger share of these SIPs flowing into established crypto assets such as Bitcoin, Ethereum and Solana means that investors are increasingly prioritising long-term value over short-term opportunities. In terms of the average ticket sizes of the SIPs, all three exchanges have marginal year-on-year change. Sumit Gupta, Co-founder, CoinDCX, suggested that the SIP ticket size has been relatively stable, with investors splitting their capital across multiple SIPs rather than increasing the size of individual investments. On the other hand, Dharendra Kumar, Founder and CEO of Value Research, said he believes that the fear of missing out on another major upswing is playing a disproportionate role. “Any speculative asset tends to lure newcomers when prices correct as people think they are being clever by buying cheap,” he added.

Cricket stars to see surge in brand valuation, endorsement deals

The T20 World Cup triumph will open doors for commercial deals for younger players too

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

India’s ICC Men’s T20 World Cup triumph is driving up brand valuations of cricketers with a surge in endorsement deals and equity deal opportunities. Captain Suryakumar Yadav and Jasprit Bumrah are expected to witness a double-digit surge in brand valuations. Experts said players such Sanju Samson and Ishan Kishan are also expected to witness an uptick in brand valuation. At the same time, the win will open doors for commercial deals for younger players too. Nikhil Bardia, Head of RISE Worldwide told *businessline*, “The 2026 World Cup triumph has officially ushered in a new commercial era. Yadav is set to com-



GAME POWER. According to experts, brands from various sectors will be looking to partner with these stars to widen their consumer base

mand a portfolio of 35+ brands fuelled by a 25 per cent leadership premium, while Bumrah’s masterclass has cemented him as a ‘National Treasure’, driving his per-deal valuation up by a massive 40 per cent.” **HOME SOIL** “The 2026 victory is commercially more potent than

2024 because winning on home soil creates a unique ‘emotional ROI’ for brands, shifting the market from simple endorsements to high-stakes equity deals. This localised marketing frenzy is expected to trigger a 40-60 per cent surge in brand value, as the ‘home hero’ sentiment drives longer-term contracts and deeper consumer trust,” he

added. According to experts, brands from various sectors will be looking to partner with these cricket stars to widen their consumer base. Umakanta Panigrahi, Managing Director, Valuation Services, Kroll said, “Players like Yadav and Bumrah are increasingly following the path set by icons such as Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma, delivering consistently both on the field and in brand campaigns. Yadav’s endorsement portfolio continues to expand with brands such as Fujiyama Power Systems and Skyscanner, reflecting his rising popularity. Similarly, Bumrah remains one of the most premium faces in Indian cricket with endorsements including Foundit, JadeBlue, OnePlus and building en-

trepreneurial credentials through investment in startups like Uppercase.” This victory also comes at a time when senior stalwarts are gradually scaling back from certain formats and players, including Yadav, Bumrah, Samson and Kishan, are emerging as the new commercial face of Indian cricket, he added. **MAJOR OPPORTUNITY** Santosh N, Managing Partner of D & P Advisory said, “The surge in brand valuations for some of the players will be significant, especially the younger players that are currently at a lower base. The T20 World Cup victory will definitely lead to more endorsement deals for these players. However, the younger players will also need to focus on consistent performance.”

Nasscom calls for contingency plans amid West Asia turmoil

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Information technology (IT) industry body Nasscom on Monday advised companies to strengthen operational preparedness and cybersecurity frameworks in the wake of the evolving geopolitical situation in West Asia, cautioning that periods of uncertainty can heighten risks of disruptions and cyber threats. Issuing a fresh advisory, the industry organisation said that while business operations currently remain stable, organisations are proactively reviewing contingency plans and strengthening resilience measures to mitigate potential disruptions should the situation evolve. “Companies are re-

viewing and activating contingency frameworks to ensure operational continuity and uninterrupted service delivery in the event of regional disruptions... organisations are prioritising employee well-being by enabling remote work arrangements and closely monitoring the situation for employees located in affected geographies,” Nasscom said. **CLOSE WATCH** Nasscom continues to monitor the evolving situation and remains in regular contact with the West Asian Council to assess developments on the ground and extend support where required, it said. Nasscom added that firms are evaluating alternate infrastructure routing to en-

sure cloud and data centre resilience and safeguard critical systems. Companies are also advising employees to limit non-essential travel and explore alternative transit routes where required. The industry body also noted that periods of geopolitical uncertainty often see a rise in coordinated cyber threats, disinformation campaigns and infrastructure targeting. Organisations are therefore advised to strengthen their cybersecurity posture and prioritise immediate actions, such as rotating credentials, accelerating patching, auditing supply chains, enforcing multi-factor authentication on all external access paths and implementing conditional access controls.

